

THE SOLO FOUNDER'S PLAYBOOK

THE ONE-PERSON STARTUP WITH AI

*How to Build a Thriving Business —
Alone — Using the Power of
Artificial Intelligence*

DILIP SAROJ

2026 EDITION



BUILD
SMARTER



AUTOMATE
MORE



GROW
FASTER



STAY
INDEPENDENT

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THE ONE-PERSON STARTUP WITH AI

How to Build a Thriving Business — Alone — Using the Power of Artificial Intelligence

First Edition · 2026

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Research and examples in this book draw on public reporting, company information, and founder statements. Verify time-sensitive claims before making decisions.

Contents

Fifteen chapters, four appendices, and a 90-day plan.

Before You Begin	How to Use This Book	5
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PART I · FOUNDATIONS

Chapter 1	The New Era of the Solo Founder	8
Chapter 2	The Solopreneur Mindset	12
Chapter 3	Finding a Niche That Pays	17

PART II · BUILDING

Chapter 4	Your AI Tool Stack	26
Chapter 5	The Five Business Models	34
Chapter 6	Building and Launching in 30 Days	39

PART III · GROWTH

Chapter 7	Distribution and Marketing	45
Chapter 8	Pricing and Monetisation	50
Chapter 9	Operations and Automation	54

PART IV · REALITY

Chapter 10	The Money Reality	59
Chapter 11	What Goes Wrong	63
Chapter 12	Six Founders, Six Paths	67
Chapter 13	Scaling Without Hiring	71

PART V · EXECUTION

Chapter 14	A Complete Worked Example	75
Chapter 15	Your 90-Day Plan	80

APPENDICES

Appendix A	The Prompt Library	85
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Appendix B	Templates and Frameworks	98
Appendix C	Operating From India	102
Appendix D	Tools and Communities	107

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

How to Use This Book

Five minutes that will save you fifty hours

This is a working manual, not a motivational book. It is built to be used with a notebook open beside it, and it assumes you intend to actually build something rather than simply read about people who did.

The structure

The book is organised in five parts that follow the real sequence of building a business. Part I covers the foundations — the mindset shift and how to choose a niche that can actually pay you. Part II covers building — your AI tool stack, the business model you will run, and how to ship a product in thirty days. Part III covers growth — marketing, pricing, and the automation that keeps you sane. Part IV is the part most books skip: what this actually costs, what actually goes wrong, and what the people who succeeded really did. Part V is execution — a complete worked example followed end to end, and your 90-day plan.

The four appendices are reference material you will return to: a library of AI prompts you can copy directly, fill-in templates, a guide for readers operating from India, and a directory of tools and communities.

Three ways to read it

- **Starting from zero.** Read straight through, in order, and complete the action steps at the end of each chapter before moving on. Expect this to take two to three weeks at a comfortable pace.
- **You already have an idea.** Read Chapter 3 first to pressure-test it, then jump to Part II. Come back to Chapter 2 if your idea does not survive the validation test — that is a feature, not a failure.
- **You already have a product but no customers.** Start at Chapter 7. Your problem is almost certainly distribution, not product.

What you will find in each chapter

Every chapter ends with a short checklist of concrete actions. Most chapters also contain one or more prompt blocks — copy-paste instructions written to be pasted directly into Claude, ChatGPT, or any capable AI assistant. These are the single most useful thing in the book. They are collected together in Appendix A so you can find them quickly later.

A note on the numbers in this book

The revenue figures you will read here are real and verifiable, but they are the visible tail of a very large distribution. For every founder earning \$145,000 a month there are thousands earning nothing, and you will not read about them. Treat these stories as proof that the ceiling is high, not as a forecast of your own results. Chapter 11 deals honestly with what typically happens instead.

One request

Do not read this book in one sitting and then do nothing. The gap between people who build something and people who do not is almost never knowledge — it is the willingness to take one small, concrete, slightly uncomfortable action within twenty-four hours of feeling motivated. Read Chapter 1, then do the first action step the same day. That single habit is worth more than the rest of this book combined.

START HERE

- ☐ Get a dedicated notebook or document for this book. You will be writing a lot.
- ☐ Block two hours in your calendar this week for Chapters 1 to 3.
- ☐ Decide now, before you read further, what "success" would mean for you in twelve months — in a number.

PART I

Foundations

Before the tools, before the tactics — the three things that determine whether any of this works.

- 1 · The New Era of the Solo Founder
 - 2 · The Solopreneur Mindset
 - 3 · Finding a Niche That Pays
-

CHAPTER 1

The New Era of the Solo Founder

Why one person can now do what took a team of twenty

In June 2025, a company with exactly one employee sold for eighty million dollars in cash. It was sixteen months old. Its founder had put in less than twenty thousand dollars of his own money and had never raised a round. This chapter is about why that stopped being impossible, and what it means for you.

The Base44 story

Maor Shlomo was thirty-one, Israeli, and freshly out of military service when he started building a side project in late 2024. The idea was simple to describe and hard to execute: what if someone with no coding ability could build working software just by describing what they wanted in plain English? He called it Base44.

He formalised it as a company in January 2025. In the early months he was pushing as many as thirteen production updates a day, checking his servers every two to three hours, and getting feedback from friends and colleagues rather than running any kind of marketing campaign. He posted about the work publicly as he did it. Growth came almost entirely through word of mouth — people used the product, liked it enough to tell others, and the loop compounded.

By May 2025 Base44 was generating around \$189,000 in monthly profit. By June it had crossed 300,000 users and roughly \$3.5 million in annual recurring revenue, with partnerships including eToro and Similarweb. Wix acquired it for \$80 million in cash. Shlomo had no co-founder and no employees.

“If I were to do it again, I would first make sure users love the product to the point where they are sharing it.”

— Maor Shlomo, founder of Base44

That sentence is the most useful thing in this entire chapter, and we will come back to it repeatedly. But first, the more important question: was Shlomo a fluke?

The data says no

The solo founder is not a curiosity any more. It is a measurable and accelerating structural shift in how companies get built.

36.3% of new US startups were solo-founded in 2025, up from 23.7% in 2019	117,060 zero-employee US businesses crossed \$1M revenue in 2023	52.3% of startups that achieved an exit had a single founder	~350 unicorns founded by a single individual
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Solo-founded ventures rose from under a quarter of new American startups in 2019 to more than a third by the first half of 2025 — a 53 percent increase that maps almost exactly onto the period in which generative AI tools became genuinely usable. The number of American businesses with no employees at all that nonetheless generate over a million dollars in annual revenue roughly doubled between 2021 and 2023, reaching more than 117,000. Across the whole non-employer economy, some 29.8 million such companies now produce approximately \$1.7 trillion in revenue, close to seven percent of US GDP.

Perhaps the most striking figure: 77 percent of solopreneurs report being profitable in their first year, compared with 54 percent of businesses that employ staff. This is not because solo founders are better operators. It is because their cost structure is almost entirely variable and almost entirely small.

What actually changed

Four things happened at roughly the same time, and their combination is what created this window.

1. The cost of producing software collapsed

Building a functional web application in 2015 required either the ability to code or roughly \$30,000 to pay someone who could. In 2026, tools like Replit, Lovable, Bubble, and Cursor let a person describe what they want and receive working software. Around 63 percent of active users on these "vibe coding" platforms are not developers. This is the single largest change, because software was historically the expensive part.

2. The cost of producing content collapsed

Content marketing used to require either a writer on staff or a meaningful freelance budget. Generative AI reduces content production time by roughly 60 to 70 percent, which means a single person can now sustain a publishing cadence that previously required a small team. Distribution, historically the hardest part of a small business, became tractable for one person.

3. Distribution became free and direct

A newsletter platform costs nothing to start. A LinkedIn account costs nothing. A YouTube channel costs nothing. Thirty years ago, reaching ten thousand relevant people required buying access to them through advertising or media. Today it requires being consistently useful in public for long enough. That is a substitution of time for capital, which is exactly the trade a person starting with no money needs.

4. Payments and infrastructure became global and instant

Stripe, Gumroad, Lemon Squeezy, Razorpay, Paddle and their competitors made it possible to sell to a customer in another country in an afternoon. Cloud compute is billed by the second. You can now start a company that serves customers on four continents without a lawyer, an office, or an initial investment beyond a few hundred dollars.

The economic consequence

A complete solopreneur software stack runs \$75 to \$150 per month — a 95 to 98 percent reduction against the equivalent staffing cost. One McKinsey analysis found AI-automated solo operations achieve 4.2× higher revenue per hour worked than manual workflows. Compute scales elastically without equity dilution, which is why solo founders retain dramatically more ownership than their venture-funded peers.

The people already doing this

Base44 is the flashiest example but it is far from the only one. A brief roll call, each covered in detail in Chapter 12:

Founder	Business	Reported result	Model
Pieter Levels	Photo AI	~\$132K MRR, 87%+ net margin	Micro-SaaS
Nevo David	Postiz	\$145K MRR, growing ~\$1K MRR/day	Micro-SaaS
Justin Welsh	Courses + newsletter	\$10M+ cumulative revenue	Audience
Dan Koe	Courses + community	\$4M+/yr at ~98% margin	Audience
Kat Norton	Miss Excel	\$2.9M/yr	Education
Dana Snyder	Nonprofit AI consulting	Hundreds of clients, 1 employee	Productised service

Note the diversity. Two of these are software products. Two are essentially media businesses that sell education. One is a productised consulting practice built by someone with no technical background at all. There is no single path here, which is good news — it means you do not need to be a developer, and it means the model can be adapted to whatever you already know.

The honest limits

It would be irresponsible to write this chapter without the counterweight, so here it is. The one-person model has real constraints, and pretending otherwise is how people waste two years.

- **AI infrastructure is not free at scale.** Founders running AI-heavy products report monthly compute bills reaching into the hundreds of thousands of dollars at the high end — genuinely comparable to salaries. Your margins are excellent until they suddenly are not.
- **You cannot be expert at everything.** As J.P. Eggers of NYU Stern puts it, "no one really has the deep, specialised knowledge you need in lots of different areas." AI narrows this gap; it does not close it. You will make bad decisions in the domains you know least.
- **Some industries are structurally closed to you.** Anything with heavy regulatory compliance, physical supply chains, or enterprise sales cycles requiring a team of humans will resist a solo operator regardless of tooling.
- **The business is you.** Shlomo was checking servers every two to three hours. If you are ill, exhausted, or simply need three weeks away, there is nobody to cover. This is the most underrated cost and Chapter 11 addresses it properly.
- **Survivorship bias is severe.** You are reading about the winners because the losers do not get written about. The base rate of failure is high.

What this chapter is actually claiming

Not that building a one-person business is easy — it is not. Not that you will earn what Shlomo earned — you probably will not. The claim is narrower and more useful: the floor of what one motivated person can build without capital, staff, or permission has risen dramatically, and the tools required now cost less than a monthly phone bill. That is genuinely new, and it is enough.

YOUR ACTION STEPS

- ☐ Write down, in one sentence, what you would build if you knew it would work.
- ☐ Look up two of the founders in the table above and read something they wrote in their own words.
- ☐ Calculate your current monthly personal expenses. That number is your real target — not a million dollars.
- ☐ Identify the single biggest reason you have not started yet. Write it down honestly.

CHAPTER 2

The Solopreneur Mindset

The operating system underneath everything else

Almost everyone who fails at this fails for psychological reasons rather than technical ones. They pick a niche and abandon it in week six. They build for four months without showing anyone. They price at a third of what they are worth because asking felt rude. None of these are knowledge problems. This chapter is about the operating system that prevents them.

The core reframe: you are not a worker, you are an architect

Most of us are trained into employment. Someone assigns work, you complete it, you are paid for the completion. The feedback loop is short and the definition of a good day is clear. Running a one-person company breaks all of this. You are simultaneously responsible for strategy, product, marketing, sales, support, finance, and administration, and on most days nobody will tell you whether you did well.

The reframe that resolves this: your job is not to do the work. Your job is to design systems that produce the work. You are an architect, not a labourer. AI is not your assistant — it is a component in the machine you are building. Every hour you spend doing something a system could do is an hour stolen from designing the system.

"Solopreneurs don't need more motivation. They need fewer decisions."

— Anfernee Chansamooth, Solopreneur Code

That line deserves unpacking, because it is the practical core of solo operating. Motivation is not a renewable resource you can schedule. Decision capacity is finite and depletes through the day. The founders who sustain output for years are not more disciplined — they have simply removed most decisions from their day by making them once, in advance, and encoding them into routines.

The five shifts

Shift 1 — From doing to designing

Every task performed more than twice is a candidate for a system. The question to ask is never "how do I do this faster" but "how do I stop being the one who does this". Most people optimise the wrong layer for years.

In practice: keep a running list titled "things I did more than once this week". Review it every Friday. Automate or template the top item.

Shift 2 — From perfection to iteration

Shlomo pushed thirteen production updates in a day. That is not carelessness — it is a recognition that the market, not your judgement, decides what is good, and the market can only tell you once something is in front of it. Perfectionism in a one-person business is almost always fear wearing a respectable coat.

In practice: set a rule that nothing may be worked on for more than two weeks before someone outside your head sees it.

Shift 3 — From lone wolf to orchestrator

Solo means you own the decisions. It does not mean you work in isolation. You have AI as a thinking partner, contractors for specialist work, and peers for perspective. The founders who burn out fastest are the ones who confuse independence with isolation.

In practice: one standing weekly conversation with another founder. Not a mastermind, not a course — one person who will ask what you shipped.

Shift 4 — From hours to outcomes

Nobody pays you for effort. The metric that matters is what changed in the world — revenue, users, published assets. AI compresses the relationship between hours and output so severely that measuring hours becomes actively misleading.

In practice: end each week by writing down what exists now that did not exist on Monday. If the answer is nothing, the week was lost regardless of how busy it felt.

Shift 5 — From fear to experimentation

Every failed product, wrong niche, and ignored launch is information you could not have bought. The founders who succeed are not braver — they have simply made their experiments small enough that failure costs a week rather than a year.

In practice: never commit more than 30 days to an unvalidated idea before requiring external evidence that someone wants it.

The daily architecture

There is no universal correct schedule, but there is a universal correct principle: the highest-value creative work must happen before the day fills with reactive work, because reactive work expands to fill whatever space it is given. A structure that works for many solo operators:

Block	Time	Purpose	Rule
Deep work	2–3 hrs, first thing	The one thing that moves the business	No email, no messages, no metrics
Build / deliver	2 hrs, late morning	Product work or client delivery	Single project, no switching
Reactive	1–2 hrs, afternoon	Email, support, admin, calls	Batched, never continuous
Review	20 min, end of day	What shipped, what is next	Written, not mental
Weekly review	60 min, Friday	Metrics, pruning, next week's one thing	Non-negotiable

Protect the first block above everything else

If you protect nothing else, protect the first two hours. Almost every solo founder who sustains output long-term has some version of this rule, and almost every one who burns out lost it first. Reactive work feels productive because it produces visible motion, but it is the only category of work that will still be there tomorrow if you ignore it today.

Building a resilience system

Operating alone means every bad day is a company-wide bad day, and there is no colleague to absorb it. Resilience is therefore not a personality trait in this context — it is infrastructure, and it can be built deliberately.

Anchor routines

A fixed start and a fixed stop. The stop matters more than the start. Without a defined end to the working day, work bleeds into every hour you are awake, and the quality of both the work and the rest degrades. Choose a time. Honour it on the days it is inconvenient, which is the only test that counts.

Decision frameworks

Pre-decide the recurring questions so they stop consuming capacity. Which clients do you accept? What is your minimum price? Which opportunities do you decline automatically? Write these down once. When the situation arises, you are consulting a rule rather than making a judgement, which costs almost nothing.

Peer accountability

One person who knows what you are working on and will ask about it. This is the single highest-return relationship in solo business and it costs one conversation a week. Indie Hackers, build-in-public communities on X, and niche Discord servers are where these relationships form.

Strategic pruning

One solopreneur documented cutting his product catalogue from over sixty items to around thirty, and described the result not as loss but as focus, bandwidth, and conviction. Every active project consumes attention even when you are not working on it. Killing things is a core competency, not an admission of failure.

Separating identity from results

A bad revenue month is information about a market, not a verdict on your worth. This sounds like a platitude until the third bad month, at which point it becomes the only thing standing between you and quitting. Founders who fuse their self-worth to their metrics do not last, because the metrics are volatile and the self-worth is not supposed to be.

"Less isn't lazy. It's often the bravest decision."

— Anfernee Chansamooth

Using AI as a thinking partner, not a shortcut

A pattern worth adopting early: use AI to pressure-test your reasoning rather than to replace it. The failure mode is asking AI what you should do and accepting the answer. The productive mode is stating your plan and asking it to attack the plan. The second produces better decisions and, importantly, keeps the judgement muscle in your hands where it belongs.

PROMPT — PRESSURE-TEST A DECISION

I am a solo founder considering the following decision:

[DESCRIBE THE DECISION AND YOUR CURRENT REASONING IN 3-5 SENTENCES]

Do not tell me it is a good idea. Instead:

1. List the three strongest arguments AGAINST this decision.
2. Identify the assumptions I am making that I have not stated.
3. Describe the most likely way this fails in the next 90 days.
4. Tell me what evidence I could gather this week that would change my mind either way.

Be direct. I would rather be corrected now than in six months.

Use this before any decision that costs more than a week of your time.

YOUR ACTION STEPS

- ☐ Write down your three recurring tasks. For each, decide: eliminate, automate, delegate, or keep.
- ☐ Choose your daily stop time and put it in your calendar as a recurring block.
- ☐ Write your three decision rules: minimum price, ideal client, automatic decline.
- ☐ Message one founder this week and propose a weekly fifteen-minute check-in.
- ☐ Run the pressure-test prompt above on whatever you are currently unsure about.

CHAPTER 3

Finding a Niche That Pays

The decision that determines whether anything else matters

You can execute perfectly against the wrong market and end with nothing. Niche selection is the highest-leverage decision in this book, and it is the one most people rush because it feels like preparation rather than progress. It is not preparation. It is the work.

What a niche actually is

A niche is not a topic. "Fitness" is a topic. "Strength programming for men over forty returning after injury" is a niche. The difference is that the second describes a specific person in a specific situation with a specific problem, which means you can find them, speak to them in language they recognise, and build something that fits their circumstances exactly.

The instinct to stay broad comes from a fear of shrinking the market. This is backwards for a solo operator. You are not trying to reach everyone; you are trying to be the obvious choice for a group small enough that you can dominate it and large enough to pay you. For most solo businesses, a market of a few thousand reachable people is entirely sufficient.

The arithmetic that makes narrow niches work

One thousand people who genuinely have your problem, of whom two percent buy a \$500 product, is \$10,000. Two hundred subscribers paying \$40 a month is \$8,000 monthly and \$96,000 a year. Twelve consulting clients at \$2,000 a month is \$288,000 a year. None of these require a large market. They require a specific one.

The three-circle test

A workable niche sits where three conditions overlap. Miss any one and the business is much harder than it needs to be.

Condition	The question to ask	How to tell it is missing
Painful problem	Are people actively spending time or money trying to solve this right now?	People find it interesting but have never searched for a solution
Willingness to pay	Does money already move in this category, and does the buyer control a budget?	Everyone loves the idea; nobody has ever paid for anything similar
Your advantage	Do you have expertise, access, unusual insight, or credible experience here?	You would be learning the domain and the business simultaneously

The third circle is the one people skip. Building a business in a domain you do not understand means you cannot tell a real problem from a fake one, you cannot write copy that resonates, and you have no credibility with buyers. You do not need to be the world expert. You need to be roughly two years ahead of the person you are serving, which is a much lower bar and one most people already clear somewhere.

The five-step research process

This takes a weekend, not a quarter. Do it properly once rather than badly three times.

Step 1 — Generate candidates from what you already know

Start from your own experience rather than from market trends. List every job you have held, every skill you have been paid for, every hobby you have gone deep on, and every problem you have personally solved for yourself. Each of these is a potential niche because in each you have the third circle already.

PROMPT — GENERATE NICHE CANDIDATES

I want to build a one-person business. Here is my background:

Work experience: [LIST ROLES AND YEARS]

Skills I have been paid for: [LIST]

Things I know unusually well: [LIST]

Problems I have solved for myself: [LIST]

Generate 20 specific niche opportunities where my background gives me a credible advantage. For each one give me:

- The specific person (role, situation, not a demographic)
- The painful problem they have
- Evidence that people already pay to solve this
- Why my background makes me credible to them

Be specific. "Small business owners" is not a person.

"Solo dental practice owners handling their own billing" is.

Run this three or four times with different emphasis. Keep the candidates that make you slightly uncomfortable — that usually means specific.

Step 2 — Validate direction with trend data

Take your best five candidates to Google Trends, Exploding Topics, and Glimpse. You are not looking for explosive growth — you are looking for stability or gentle growth over three to five years. A declining curve means you would be fighting the market. A vertical spike often means a fad that will be gone before you finish building.

Step 3 — Mine communities for real language

This step produces more value than the other four combined, and almost nobody does it properly. Find the places your candidate audience actually gathers — subreddits, Facebook groups, Discord servers, niche forums, the comment sections of relevant YouTube channels. Read for two hours. Copy every complaint, question, and frustrated post into a document verbatim.

The exact words people use to describe their problems are the exact words that should appear on your landing page. This is the difference between copy that converts and copy that sounds like every other website in the category.

PROMPT — ANALYSE COMMUNITY PAIN POINTS

Below are real posts and comments from [COMMUNITY NAME], where [TARGET AUDIENCE] gather. Analyse them and tell me:

1. The five most frequently expressed frustrations, ranked
2. The exact phrases people use to describe each one
3. Which frustrations appear to cost them money or significant time
4. What they have already tried and why it did not work
5. Any problem that appears repeatedly but has no obvious existing solution

Quote their actual language. Do not paraphrase into marketing speak.

POSTS:

[PASTE 30-50 POSTS OR COMMENTS HERE]

Step 4 — Study the competition properly

Competition is a positive signal. It proves money moves in this category and that you do not have to educate the market on why the problem matters. What you are looking for is not an empty market but an underserved segment inside a proven one — the customers existing products treat as an afterthought.

- Read one-star and three-star reviews of competing products. Three-star reviews are the most valuable text on the internet for this purpose: the customer wanted to like it and can articulate precisely why they could not.
- Identify who each competitor is clearly built for, then ask who is buying it despite not being that person. That group is your opportunity.
- Check pricing. If everyone charges \$9/month, the category may have a ceiling. If prices range from \$9 to \$500, there is room to position.

Step 5 — Test willingness to pay before building

This is the step that separates people who build businesses from people who build projects. Before you write code or record a course, you need evidence that someone will part with money. Ranked from weakest to strongest signal:

Signal	What it proves	Strength
Survey response saying "I would buy this"	Almost nothing	Very weak
Email waitlist signup	Mild interest, low cost to give	Weak
A scheduled call to discuss the problem	The problem is real to them	Moderate
Pre-order or deposit, even \$10	Genuine intent	Strong
Payment for a manual version you deliver by hand	The business works	Decisive

The manual-first test

The strongest possible validation is to deliver the outcome manually, by hand, for money, before building anything. If you plan to build software that generates social media content, first sell five people a month of content that you produce yourself with AI assistance. If they pay, you have proven demand, learned the workflow in detail, and earned revenue that funds the build. If they do not pay, you have saved three months.

Scoring your candidates

Run each surviving candidate through this scorecard. Score each criterion from 1 to 5, then total. Anything under 24 out of 40 is likely to be painful; anything over 32 is worth committing to.

#	Criterion	Score 1	Score 5
1	Problem urgency	Mild annoyance	Costs them money weekly
2	Willingness to pay	No precedent	Already paying competitors
3	Your credibility	Complete outsider	Genuine domain experience
4	Audience reachability	Scattered, no venue	Concentrated in known places
5	Market size	Under 500 people	Tens of thousands reachable
6	Competition quality	Dominated by giants	Weak or generic incumbents
7	Delivery feasibility	Needs a team	You can deliver alone with AI
8	Your genuine interest	Would bore you in a month	Could do this for five years

Niche scorecard — fill this in

Candidate niche (the specific person and their problem):

.....

Where do they gather? (list 3 specific places)

.....

What are they already paying for?

.....

Total score out of 40:

.....

Categories that suit solo operators in 2026

Category	Why it works for one person	Typical range
Vertical micro-SaaS	Narrow scope, predictable revenue, low support burden	\$5K–\$50K MRR
Productised service	Fastest to revenue; AI multiplies delivery capacity	\$3K–\$15K/mo
Professional education	Very high margin, no inventory, global market	\$10K–\$100K/yr
Automation consulting	Huge demand, low tooling barrier, retainer revenue	\$2K–\$10K/client
Niche media + products	Compounds; owns distribution permanently	\$2K–\$25K/mo
AI-native tooling	Small workflows AI now makes solvable	\$3K–\$30K MRR

The passion trap

The most common failure in niche selection is choosing something you find personally fascinating without checking whether anyone pays to solve problems in it. Passion is genuinely necessary — it is what carries you through month seven — but it is a tiebreaker, not a criterion. Choose from the set of niches that pay, and within that set pick the one you find most interesting. Not the other way around.

When to abandon a niche

Commitment matters, but so does honesty. Reasonable grounds to move on: you have spoken to twenty people in the target market and none described the problem without being prompted; you have published consistently for ninety days with no organic engagement whatsoever; you have offered the solution for money to fifteen qualified people and nobody bought. Unreasonable grounds: it has been three weeks and it feels slow. Almost everything feels slow at three weeks.

YOUR ACTION STEPS

- ☐ Complete Step 1 today: list your roles, paid skills, deep knowledge, and self-solved problems.
- ☐ Run the niche generation prompt and select your five strongest candidates.
- ☐ Spend two hours in communities. Copy fifty verbatim complaints into a document.
- ☐ Score your top three candidates on the eight-criterion scorecard.
- ☐ Book three conversations with people in your leading niche this week. Ask about the problem — do not pitch.

PART II

Building

Your tools, your business model, and getting something real in front of a paying human being.

4 · Your AI Tool Stack

5 · The Five Business Models

6 · Building and Launching in 30 Days

CHAPTER 4

Your AI Tool Stack

Assembling a virtual company for the price of a phone bill

The correct number of tools is far smaller than you think. Most new solopreneurs subscribe to a dozen products in their first month, use three of them badly, and conclude that AI is overhyped. The founders getting real leverage typically run four or five tools that they understand deeply. This chapter is about which ones and, more importantly, why.

The principle: buy capability, not software

Think of your stack as a set of roles you are filling rather than a set of products you are purchasing. A one-person business needs a thinking partner, a connective layer that moves information between systems, somewhere to keep its knowledge, a way to produce visuals, and a way to establish facts. Five roles. Almost everything else is a specialisation you add later when a specific bottleneck appears.

Add tools only in response to pain

The correct trigger for adding a tool is a sentence of the form: "I lose four hours every week doing X, and this tool removes three of them." If you cannot complete that sentence with a specific number, you are collecting rather than building. Collecting feels like progress and is not.

The core five

THE THINKING PARTNER

Claude or ChatGPT

\$20/month

This is the tool you will use for eighty percent of everything: drafting, editing, research synthesis, strategy pressure-testing, customer emails, code assistance, analysing feedback, and structured thinking. Claude handles very long documents and careful reasoning well, with a large context window that lets you paste entire documents in for analysis. ChatGPT has the broader plugin ecosystem, native image generation, and voice. Many founders run both; if you run one, choose based on which produces writing that sounds more like you with less editing.

Start here. If you buy nothing else, buy this.

THE CONNECTIVE TISSUE

Zapier or Make

\$20–30/month

Automation platforms move information between your other tools without you touching anything. A payment arrives and a customer record is created, a welcome sequence starts, and a task appears in your project board. Zapier is simpler and has around 7,000 integrations; Make handles complex branching logic better but takes longer to learn. For a self-hosted, free alternative with a steeper curve, n8n is excellent.

Buy this the moment you have your first repeated manual workflow.

THE COMPANY BRAIN

Notion

Free–\$20/month

Every business accumulates knowledge — strategy documents, customer notes, content calendars, standard procedures, project plans. Without a single home, that knowledge lives in your head, which means it is unavailable when you are tired and lost when you are ill. Notion is the most common choice; the specific tool matters far less than having exactly one.

Free tier is genuinely sufficient for a long time.

THE DESIGN DEPARTMENT

Canva

Free–\$13/month

Social graphics, lead magnets, course slides, ad creative, product mockups, and covers. Canva's AI features generate complete templated designs from a text description, which removes the need for design skill entirely at the quality level most solo businesses require.

Free tier covers most needs; upgrade for brand kits and background removal.

THE RESEARCH ANALYST

Perplexity

Free–\$20/month

Cited, current answers rather than confident guesses. Use it before writing anything factual, entering a new market, or making a claim in your marketing. The citation trail matters — it lets you verify rather than trust, which is the correct relationship to have with any AI output.

The free tier is adequate for most research volume.

Specialist additions

Add these only when the relevant bottleneck is real and measurable.

If you are building software

Tool	What it does	Cost
Cursor	AI-native code editor; inline edits, codebase-wide chat, refactors. Reported 30–50% saving on routine coding.	\$20/mo
Replit	Build and deploy in the browser with AI assistance. Used by non-technical founders to ship real products.	Free–\$25/mo
Lovable / Bubble	Describe an app in plain language and get working software. No-code and vibe-code builders.	\$20–\$40/mo
RunPod	GPU compute billed per second, materially cheaper than AWS or GCP for model inference.	Pay per use

If you are producing content

Tool	What it does	Cost
ElevenLabs	AI voice for narration, podcasts, and multilingual audio at broadcast quality.	\$5–\$22/mo
Descript	Edit video and audio by editing the transcript. Removes filler words automatically.	\$12–\$24/mo
Postiz / Buffer	Schedule and publish across many platforms from one workflow. Postiz covers 30+ channels.	\$19–\$29/mo
Beehiiv / Kit	Newsletter platform with growth tooling, referrals, and monetisation built in.	Free–\$49/mo

If you are running a service business

Tool	What it does	Cost
Lindy	AI agents for inbox triage, meeting follow-up, and CRM hygiene.	Free–\$49/mo
Granola / Otter	Call recording with structured summaries and extracted action items.	\$15–\$25/mo
Cal.com / Calendly	Scheduling without the coordination emails.	Free–\$15/mo
Stripe / Razorpay	Payments, invoicing, subscriptions, and dunning. See Appendix C for India.	~1–3% per txn

Three stacks by stage

Stage	Stack	Monthly	When you are here
Testing	One AI assistant + free tiers of Notion and Canva	\$0–\$20	You have not validated anything yet
Operating	AI assistant + Zapier + Notion + Canva + Perplexity	\$50–\$90	You have customers and repeated workflows
Scaling	Above + Cursor or Descript + scheduling + agents	\$130–\$220	Revenue is consistent and a bottleneck is costing you real hours

The spending ceiling

Do not exceed roughly \$200 a month on tooling until you have consistent revenue. This is not frugality for its own sake — it is that tool spending is the easiest possible substitute for the uncomfortable work of talking to customers and selling things. A founder with an elaborate stack and no customers has usually been avoiding something.

Getting genuinely good at the AI assistant

The gap between people who find AI transformative and people who find it disappointing is almost entirely about how they use it. Four habits close most of that gap.

Give it context before you give it a task

A request with no context produces generic output, which you then reject, concluding the tool is weak. Front-load who you are, who the audience is, what you are trying to achieve, and what good looks like. A prompt that takes ninety seconds to write produces output you can actually use.

Ask for critique, not just production

AI is often more valuable as an editor than as a writer. Draft badly and quickly yourself, then ask for a structural critique. This preserves your voice, which is the thing that actually differentiates you, while still getting the speed benefit.

Build a reusable prompt library

Any prompt you have written twice should be saved. Over a year this becomes a genuine operational asset — a set of encoded procedures that produce consistent output. Appendix A contains a starter library you can adapt.

Verify anything that matters

AI produces confident, fluent, plausible errors. Treat every factual claim, statistic, legal statement, and calculation as unverified until you have checked it. The reputational cost of publishing a fabricated statistic is far higher than the time cost of checking it.

PROMPT — SET UP YOUR STANDING CONTEXT

I am going to work with you regularly. Here is my context – please keep it in mind for everything in this conversation.

BUSINESS: [what you sell, to whom]

AUDIENCE: [the specific person, their situation, their problem]

MY VOICE: [direct/warm/technical/irreverent – and 2 examples of phrasing you would and would not use]

GOAL THIS QUARTER: [one specific measurable objective]

CONSTRAINTS: [time available, budget, skills you lack]

When I ask for writing, match my voice rather than a generic professional register. When I ask for advice, prioritise things I can execute alone this week over strategies requiring a team. If a request is based on a bad assumption, say so first.

Paste this at the start of any substantial working session. It changes output quality more than any other single habit.

YOUR ACTION STEPS

- ☐ Pick one AI assistant and commit to it for thirty days. Do not evaluate alternatives during that time.
- ☐ Write and save your standing context prompt today.
- ☐ Identify one repeated manual workflow and build a single Zapier automation for it this week.
- ☐ Cancel any subscription you have not opened in the last fourteen days.

CHAPTER 5

The Five Business Models

Choosing the shape of the machine before you build it

Business models differ enormously in how quickly they pay, how much they compound, and how much of your time they consume forever. Choosing badly means either starving while you wait for a slow model to mature, or building something that can never detach from your hours. This chapter is about choosing deliberately.

The two axes that matter

Every model in this chapter can be placed on two dimensions. The first is time to first revenue — how long before money arrives. The second is decoupling — how much revenue can grow without your hours growing with it. Services pay immediately and decouple poorly. Software pays slowly and decouples completely. Neither is superior; they are different trades, and the right answer usually involves starting on one and migrating toward the other.

Model	First revenue	Decoupling	Skill required	Ceiling
Productised service	Days	Low	Existing professional skill	Your capacity
Automation agency	Days–weeks	Low–medium	Systems thinking	Your capacity
Digital products	1–4 months	High	Teaching, domain depth	Very high
Micro-SaaS	3–9 months	Very high	Building or vibe-coding	Unlimited
Audience business	6–18 months	High	Consistent communication	Audience-bound

MODEL 1

The Productised Service

You deliver a specific, well-defined outcome for a fixed price on a fixed timeline, using AI to compress the delivery work dramatically. Not hourly consulting — a defined package with a defined deliverable.

- Fastest possible path to revenue. You can sell this in week one with no product built.
- AI genuinely multiplies delivery capacity here: research, drafting, analysis, and reporting all compress.
- Every engagement teaches you the customer's problem in depth, which is the raw material for a product later.
- Requires no audience, no code, and no upfront investment beyond your own time.

Examples: an SEO content package delivered monthly; a financial model built to spec; a brand identity system; a technical audit with a written remediation plan.

Best for: anyone with an existing professional skill. This is the correct starting point for the large majority of readers, including those who ultimately want to build software. It funds the build and validates the market simultaneously.

MODEL 2

The Automation Agency

You build AI and automation workflows for other businesses — connecting their tools, removing their manual processes, deploying agents — and charge a setup fee plus an ongoing retainer for maintenance and improvement.

- Demand substantially exceeds supply. Most businesses know they should automate and have nobody who can.
- The retainer component produces recurring revenue without the multi-month build of a SaaS.
- The technical barrier is low: Zapier, Make, and n8n require logic rather than programming.
- Typical economics: \$2,000–\$10,000 setup plus \$500–\$2,000 monthly retainer per client.

Ten retainer clients at \$1,500 is \$180,000 a year, which is achievable within twelve to eighteen months of consistent outreach.

Best for: systems thinkers who enjoy diagnosing messy processes. Also an excellent bridge business — it pays well while you build something with a higher ceiling.

MODEL 3

Digital Products and Courses

You package what you know into a course, template set, playbook, or toolkit. Built once, sold indefinitely, delivered automatically.

- Margins of 90 to 99 percent. No inventory, no delivery cost, no marginal cost per sale.
- Can be launched in days on Gumroad, Podia, or Teachable — the platform is not the hard part.
- Compounds powerfully when paired with an audience: each new subscriber is a future buyer.
- Examples: Kat Norton built Miss Excel to \$2.9M/year; Justin Welsh has passed \$10M cumulative.

The common failure is building a large course before establishing that anyone wants it. Sell a live cohort first — the same content, delivered manually — then record it.

Best for: people with genuine domain expertise who enjoy explaining things. Note that "expertise" here means two years ahead of your buyer, not world-class.

MODEL 4

Micro-SaaS

A narrow software product solving one specific problem for one specific audience, sold by subscription. Deliberately small in scope — the opposite of a platform.

- The strongest decoupling of any model: revenue grows without your hours growing.
- Recurring revenue makes the business predictable and, eventually, sellable.
- Vibe-coding tools mean non-developers can now build this. 63% of their users are non-technical.
- Examples: Postiz at \$145K MRR; Photo AI at ~\$132K MRR with 87%+ net margins.

The trade is time: expect three to nine months before meaningful revenue, and expect the first version to be wrong. Support burden is real and grows with users.

Best for: builders with patience and, ideally, an existing audience or service business generating cash while the product matures.

MODEL 5

The Audience Business

You build a following around a specific topic through consistent publishing — newsletter, video, or social — and monetise through products, sponsorship, community membership, and affiliate revenue.

- Owns its distribution permanently. Every other model depends on renting attention; this one owns it.
- Extremely high margins. Dan Koe reports roughly 98 percent at \$4M+ annually.
- Compounds more than any other model — audience assets appreciate rather than depreciate.
- Costs almost nothing to start: the input is consistency, not capital.

The trade is severe: six to eighteen months before meaningful money, and the first six months feel like shouting into a void. Most people quit here.

Best for: people who can sustain output without external validation for a long time, and who have something genuinely distinctive to say.

The stacking sequence

The most financially resilient solo businesses are not single-model. They stack, and the order matters. A sequence that repeatedly works:

Phase	What you do	Why this order
Months 1–6	Productised service in your niche	Immediate revenue, deep customer knowledge, zero build risk
Months 3–12	Publish consistently about the work	Builds distribution using material the service generates anyway
Months 9–18	Package the repeated engagement into a product	You now know exactly what to build and have buyers waiting
Months 18+	Automate delivery; raise service prices	Product income allows you to serve fewer, better-paying clients

Justin Welsh followed almost exactly this arc: consultant, then LinkedIn publisher, then course seller — reaching \$1M cumulative in twenty-nine months and \$10M+ by 2025. The publishing was fuelled by the consulting, and the courses were fuelled by the publishing.

Choose one to start. Only one.

The temptation is to start a service, a newsletter, and a product simultaneously because each is individually cheap to begin. Do not. A solo operator running three unvalidated initiatives will do all three badly and learn nothing conclusive from any of them. Pick the one that matches your situation, run it for ninety days, and add the second only when the first has a repeatable process.

Model selection — decide now

Which model am I starting with, and why is it right for my situation?

.....

What is my target date for first revenue?

.....

Which model am I stacking second, and roughly when?

.....

YOUR ACTION STEPS

- ☐ Choose your starting model and write one sentence explaining why it fits your situation.
- ☐ If you chose a service model, define your first package: outcome, timeline, and price.
- ☐ Write down the date by which you intend to collect your first payment.
- ☐ Identify which model you will stack second, and what has to be true before you start it.

CHAPTER 6

Building and Launching in 30 Days

Ship something real before you lose your nerve

The characteristic failure of first-time founders is building in private for months and emerging with a polished product that nobody wants and nobody has heard of. This chapter is a thirty-day structure designed specifically to make that impossible.

Why thirty days

Not because everything worthwhile can be built in a month — it cannot. The constraint exists because a deadline forces scope decisions that would otherwise be avoided indefinitely, and because motivation has a half-life. The version of you that is excited today will not be around in four months if nothing has happened. Thirty days is long enough to build something real and short enough to stay excited.

The schedule

Days 1–5

Validate

No building. This week exists to establish that the problem is real and that someone will pay. Have ten conversations with people in your target market — not pitches, conversations. Ask what they currently do about the problem, what they have tried, and what it costs them. Put up a single landing page describing the outcome and collect email addresses. If ten conversations produce no recognition of the problem, stop and return to Chapter 3. That is a successful week, not a failed one.

Deliverable: ten conversation notes and a live landing page.

Days 6–12

Build the smallest useful version

The scope rule: your first version should do one thing, for one person, in one situation. Not a platform — a single working outcome. Use AI to generate first drafts of everything: interface copy, code, structure, onboarding text. Manual is acceptable and often preferable — if the customer receives the outcome, they do not care that you produced it by hand. Set a hard rule that if a feature is not required for the core outcome, it does not exist in version one.

Deliverable: something a stranger could use and receive value from.

Days 13–19

Ten founding users

Still no public launch. Take the ten people from week one and give them access, free or heavily discounted, in exchange for honest feedback. Watch them use it if you possibly can — you will learn more from three minutes of watching someone get stuck than from thirty survey responses. Shlomo started with friends and colleagues before any public launch, and treated their reactions as the primary signal.

Deliverable: ten people who have actually used it, and written notes on where they struggled.

Days 20–25

Iterate on what you learned

Fix the top three to five issues. Not everything requested — the things that stand between a user and the outcome. The test to apply: would any of these ten people recommend this to a colleague without being asked? If the answer is no, you are not ready to launch, and launching louder will not fix it.

Deliverable: a version at least one person has voluntarily recommended.

Days 26–30

Launch publicly

Product Hunt, your newsletter, LinkedIn, X, relevant subreddits and communities where you have been a genuine participant. Write the launch as a story rather than an announcement — what problem you noticed, what you tried, what your first users said. Your founding users' words are more persuasive than anything you can write about yourself. Email everyone on your waitlist personally.

Deliverable: a public launch and your first non-founding customer.

Scoping ruthlessly

The single most useful skill in week two is deciding what not to build. A test that works: for every proposed feature, ask whether a customer would refuse to pay without it. If they would still pay, it is not in version one. Accounts, settings pages, dashboards, integrations, and dark mode are almost never required for a customer to receive the core outcome.

PROMPT — CUT YOUR SCOPE

I am building the first version of [PRODUCT] for [SPECIFIC USER].
The core outcome they want is: [OUTCOME].

Here is everything I was planning to build:
[LIST EVERY FEATURE]

Act as a ruthless product manager whose only goal is shipping in 7 days. For each feature tell me: KEEP (required for the core outcome), FAKE (can be done manually behind the scenes at first), or CUT (not needed until at least 100 users).

Then describe the smallest version that still delivers the outcome, and estimate how long it would take to build.
Be aggressive. I would rather ship something embarrassing than ship nothing.

Building without being a developer

Vibe coding — describing software in plain language and receiving working code — has removed the technical barrier for a large class of products. Dana Snyder built an AI-powered consulting platform for nonprofits on Replit with no technical background whatsoever; it now serves hundreds of clients and she remains its only full-time employee. Around 63 percent of people actively using these tools are not developers.

The realistic assessment: these tools work very well for standard web applications with common patterns — forms, dashboards, content, payments, user accounts. They struggle with genuinely novel technical problems, heavy data processing, and anything requiring careful security design. For the large majority of first products, that limitation will not bind.

What to build with, by situation

- **Software product, non-technical:** Replit, Lovable, or Bubble.
- **Software product, some coding ability:** Cursor with a standard framework.
- **Digital product or course:** Gumroad or Podia. Do not build a custom platform.
- **Newsletter:** Beehiiv or Kit. Never build this yourself.
- **Service business:** A one-page site, a scheduling link, and an invoice. Nothing else.

Writing a launch that people read

Most launch posts fail because they describe the product. Effective launch posts describe the problem, in the reader's own language, and only then mention that something now exists which solves it. The structure that consistently works:

1. The problem, stated as the reader experiences it — specific, concrete, ideally slightly painful to read.
2. What you tried first and why it did not work. This establishes credibility and is the part people actually enjoy.
3. What you built, described in terms of outcome rather than features.
4. What your first users said, quoted directly.
5. A single, clear, low-friction call to action.

PROMPT — DRAFT YOUR LAUNCH POST

Write a launch post for [PLATFORM: Product Hunt / LinkedIn / X].

Product: [WHAT IT DOES]

For: [SPECIFIC USER]

Problem it solves: [IN THEIR WORDS, FROM YOUR RESEARCH]

What I tried before building it: [YOUR STORY]

What early users said: [ACTUAL QUOTES]

My voice: [DIRECT / WARM / TECHNICAL / DRY]

Structure it as: problem → what I tried → what I built →
what users said → one clear call to action.

Rules: no hype words, no "excited to announce", no emoji walls.

Lead with the problem, not the product. Write like a person
telling a friend what they have been working on.

What to expect

Your launch will almost certainly underperform your expectations. Product Hunt will not change your life. Most launches produce a small spike followed by silence. This is normal and is not a verdict on the product. The businesses in this book were built by sustained distribution over months, not by a single launch day — Postiz grew by roughly \$1,000 MRR per day through accumulated word of mouth, not a viral moment.

YOUR ACTION STEPS

- ☐ Book five conversations for this week. Do not build anything until they are done.
- ☐ Put up a landing page within 48 hours, even if it is a single paragraph and an email field.
- ☐ Run the scope-cutting prompt and delete at least half your planned features.
- ☐ Set your launch date now and tell at least one person what it is.

PART III

Growth

Getting found, getting paid properly, and building the systems that let one person carry it all.

7 · Distribution and Marketing

8 · Pricing and Monetisation

9 · Operations and Automation

CHAPTER 7

Distribution and Marketing

The unfair advantage nobody can take from you

A mediocre product with excellent distribution beats an excellent product with none, every time, and it is not close. Most solo founders discover this after building something good that nobody ever sees. This chapter is about building the distribution first, or at minimum alongside.

The one asset that compounds

Almost everything in a business depreciates. Code rots, tactics stop working, ad platforms raise prices, algorithms change. One asset appreciates: a group of people who know who you are, trust your judgement, and have given you permission to contact them. Every product you ever launch will be launched to that group. Every pivot will be survivable because of it.

This is why the audience business in Chapter 5 was described as owning distribution while every other model rents it. You can rent attention through advertising for as long as you can afford it. You own it when ten thousand people have chosen to hear from you.

“Document, don't create. Share your process, your thinking, your mistakes — people would rather follow a story than be marketed to.”

— A principle widely attributed to Gary Vaynerchuk, adopted across the build-in-public movement

Building in public

Building in public means publishing the process as it happens: what you are working on, what broke, what you learned, what the numbers are. It works for three reasons that have nothing to do with virality. First, it is far easier to sustain than polished content, because the raw material is generated by the work you are doing anyway. Second, it accumulates an audience of people who are invested in the outcome before you have anything to sell. Third, it produces feedback early enough to change course cheaply.

Base44 reached 300,000 users with no marketing spend, driven by word of mouth and a founder who documented the journey publicly rather than running campaigns. Postiz grew the same way. This is not a coincidence and it is not luck — it is the natural result of being visibly

useful in public for long enough that people start recommending you.

What to publish when you have nothing to show yet

- The problem you are working on, and why it bothers you specifically.
- What you tried that did not work — this outperforms success posts consistently.
- Something you learned this week that would have saved you time a month ago.
- A decision you are facing, framed as a genuine question to your audience.
- A teardown of how someone else solved a related problem well.

The content engine: one week in two hours

The sustainable pattern for a solo operator is not producing content every day. It is producing one substantial piece and systematically deriving everything else from it. Generative AI reduces content production time by roughly 60 to 70 percent, which is what makes this feasible for one person.

Day	Activity	Time	Output
Monday	Write or record the cornerstone piece	90 min	One newsletter, article, or video
Tuesday	Extract short-form pieces with AI, edit for voice	30 min	5–10 posts queued for the week
Wed–Fri	Scheduled publishing runs automatically	0 min	Consistent presence with no daily effort
Saturday	Reply to comments, engage in communities	30 min	Relationships and feedback

The one thing in that table you should never automate is Saturday. Replying to people individually is where audiences actually form, and it is the only part AI genuinely cannot do for you — not because it lacks the capability, but because the value comes precisely from the fact that a real person spent their attention on someone.

PROMPT — EXTRACT A WEEK OF CONTENT FROM ONE PIECE

Below is a long-form piece I wrote. Extract short-form content from it for the coming week.

MY AUDIENCE: [SPECIFIC PERSON AND SITUATION]

MY VOICE: [DESCRIPTION + 2 SAMPLE SENTENCES]

PLATFORMS: [LINKEDIN / X / INSTAGRAM / etc.]

Produce:

- 3 LinkedIn posts (150-250 words, one idea each, no hashtag spam)
- 2 X threads (5-7 posts, strong first line)
- 1 short-video script (45 seconds, hook in first 3 seconds)

Rules:

- Each piece must stand alone and be useful without the original
- Use my actual phrasing where possible, not generic LinkedIn voice
- No "Here is the thing:" / "Let that sink in" / engagement bait
- Lead with the specific, not the abstract

SOURCE PIECE:

[PASTE YOUR CORNERSTONE CONTENT]

Choosing your channel

One channel, chosen deliberately, worked for ninety days. Not five channels worked inconsistently. The choice should follow your audience and your natural format, in that order.

Channel	Best for	Time to traction	The real cost
Newsletter	B2B, courses, depth, ownership	3–9 months	Slow start; you own the list permanently
LinkedIn	B2B services, consulting, SaaS	2–6 months	Fastest B2B channel; platform-dependent
X / Twitter	Tech, indie hacking, SaaS	3–9 months	High noise; excellent for peer network
YouTube	Education, software demos, trust	6–18 months	Highest production cost; highest trust
TikTok / Reels	Consumer products, wide reach	1–4 months	Fast reach, weak intent, poor conversion
SEO / blog	Evergreen demand capture	6–12 months	Slowest; compounds indefinitely
Reddit / forums	Niche B2B, technical audiences	Immediate	Must genuinely participate or be rejected

The ninety-day rule

Do not evaluate a channel before ninety days of consistent publishing. Almost every channel produces close to nothing for the first six to eight weeks, and the founders who succeed are frequently the ones who simply did not stop during that window. If you cannot commit to ninety days, choose a different channel — or accept that distribution is not where you are competing.

SEO for solo operators

Search is the highest-leverage long-term channel because it captures people at the moment they are actively looking for a solution, and because a good page continues working for years. The approach that suits a solo operator is to ignore high-volume competitive terms entirely and target long-tail queries with clear intent — the specific, slightly awkward phrases someone types when they have a real problem.

- Target queries with obvious commercial intent: "how to X for Y", "best tool for Z under \$50", "alternative to [competitor] for [niche]".
- Write for the person, not the algorithm. The single most reliable SEO strategy in 2026 is producing the genuinely most useful page on a narrow topic.
- Use AI to research and structure, then write the substance yourself. Wholly AI-generated content on competitive topics performs poorly and is increasingly penalised.
- Twenty excellent pages beat two hundred adequate ones, and cost less to maintain.

Cold outreach, done without shame

For service and agency models, outreach outperforms content for the first six months because it produces revenue in weeks rather than quarters. The version that works is specific, researched, short, and asks for something small.

PROMPT — WRITE A COLD OUTREACH MESSAGE

Write a short cold outreach message.

I offer: [SPECIFIC SERVICE AND OUTCOME]

Recipient: [ROLE] at [COMPANY]

Something specific I noticed about them: [REAL OBSERVATION – a recent post, a page on their site, a job listing, a gap]

Proof I can do this: [RESULT, CLIENT, OR RELEVANT EXPERIENCE]

Rules:

- Under 120 words
- Open with the specific observation, not with me
- One clear outcome, quantified if possible
- Ask for a reply, not a 30-minute call
- No flattery, no "hope this finds you well", no fake urgency
- Sound like a person who has done this work, not a template

Send fifteen of these a day, personalised individually. Ten replies from fifteen hundred sends is normal; two clients from ten replies is a business.

YOUR ACTION STEPS

- ☐ Choose one channel. Write the date ninety days from now in your calendar as the evaluation point.
- ☐ Produce your first cornerstone piece this week and extract five short pieces from it.
- ☐ List twenty specific people or companies you could contact directly this month.
- ☐ Set up one scheduling tool so publishing does not depend on your daily attention.

CHAPTER 8

Pricing and Monetisation

Charging properly is a skill, and you are probably bad at it

Almost every solo founder underprices, and the reason is emotional rather than analytical. Raising your price is usually the single fastest available improvement to a solo business, because it requires no new customers, no new product, and no new marketing — only nerve.

Why you are underpricing

Three causes, all of them psychological. The first is that you know exactly how the sausage is made — you know the work took four hours and you feel fraudulent charging two thousand for it. The customer does not care how long it took; they care what it is worth to them. The second is fear of rejection, which makes a low price feel safe when it is actually the riskiest option, because low prices attract the most difficult customers. The third is that you are comparing yourself to the cheapest visible competitor rather than to the cost of the problem going unsolved.

The AI-era pricing paradox

You might expect AI to push prices down, since everyone now has access to the same capabilities. In practice the opposite happens for expert services. When AI makes production cheap, the scarce input becomes judgement — knowing what to produce, for whom, and why. Clients are not paying for the output any more; they are paying for the decision about what the output should be. That has become more valuable, not less.

Four pricing models

Value-based pricing

Price on the outcome delivered rather than the effort expended. If your work saves a client \$60,000 annually or generates \$200,000 in additional revenue, a \$15,000 fee is straightforwardly good value for them, regardless of whether it took you forty hours or four. This requires you to understand and be able to articulate the financial impact of the problem, which is itself a skill worth developing.

Subscription and retainer

Recurring revenue is worth substantially more than equivalent one-off revenue because it is predictable, it compounds, and it makes the business valuable to a potential acquirer. Offer annual plans at a 15 to 20 percent discount — the discount costs you less than the cash flow certainty is worth, and annual customers churn less.

Usage-based pricing

Common for AI-native products: charge per document processed, per API call, per generation, per outcome produced. It aligns your revenue with the value the customer receives and scales without renegotiation. The risk is unpredictability for the customer, which many buyers dislike; hybrid models — a base subscription plus usage above a threshold — resolve most of that objection.

Outcome-based pricing

Payment tied to a measurable result: qualified leads delivered, meetings booked, revenue attributed, cost reduced. It is the easiest model to sell because the buyer carries almost no risk, and the hardest to operate because attribution disputes are inevitable. Use it selectively, with clearly defined measurement agreed in writing before starting.

The revenue pyramid

A resilient solo business sells at more than one price point, because different buyers are ready for different levels of commitment and because the lower tiers feed the upper ones.

Tier	What it is	Price band	Its job
Entry	Newsletter, free tool, template, short guide	\$0–\$50	Discovery and trust; feeds everything above
Core	Course, subscription, group programme	\$100–\$1,000	The volume revenue engine
Premium	1:1 consulting, done-for-you, advisory	\$1,000–\$10,000+	Margin, depth, and direct customer insight

The premium tier does something beyond revenue that founders consistently underestimate: working closely with a small number of clients is the highest-quality market research available anywhere, and it directly informs what belongs in the core product. Many founders keep a small consulting practice indefinitely purely for this reason.

Revenue streams compared

Stream	Setup	To revenue	Passive	Gross margin	Ceiling
Productised service	Low	Days	No	70–90%	Your hours
Retainer / agency	Low	Weeks	No	60–80%	Your hours
Digital product	Low–med	1–4 months	Yes	90–99%	Very high
Online course	Medium	2–6 months	Mostly	85–95%	Very high
SaaS subscription	High	3–9 months	Yes	60–85%	Unlimited
Community membership	Medium	3–6 months	Partly	75–90%	High
Sponsorship	Medium	6–18 months	Partly	90–98%	Audience-bound
Affiliate	Low	3–9 months	Yes	95%+	Audience-bound

How to raise your prices

Mechanically simple, emotionally difficult. The approach that minimises both risk and anxiety:

1. Raise the price for new customers only. Existing customers keep their rate — this removes the fear of losing your current base entirely.
2. Increase by 20 to 30 percent, not 5 percent. Small increases are absorbed without teaching you anything.
3. Quote the new price to the next five prospects without explanation, apology, or a discount offer.
4. Track the conversion rate. If four of five still buy, you are still underpriced. Raise again.
5. Only when roughly half decline have you found the edge of the market — and your revenue at that point is almost always higher than before.

The uncomfortable arithmetic

Ten clients at \$1,000 is \$10,000 a month and ten relationships to manage. Six clients at \$2,000 is \$12,000 a month and four fewer people to serve. The higher price is not only more profitable, it is less work, and the clients who pay it are typically more serious, better prepared, and easier to satisfy. Cheap clients are expensive.

PROMPT — JUSTIFY A PRICE TO YOURSELF

I provide [SERVICE / PRODUCT] to [SPECIFIC CUSTOMER].

Help me build the value case for pricing this properly.

1. What does this problem cost my customer if unsolved?
Consider: wasted hours, lost revenue, cost of the wrong decision, opportunity cost, cost of the alternative solutions they are currently using.
2. Quantify it in money per month and per year where possible, stating your assumptions explicitly.
3. Given that, what is a defensible price range?
4. Write three sentences I can say aloud that justify the top of that range, framed around their outcome rather than my effort.
5. List the three objections I am most likely to hear and how to answer each honestly.

Context on my customer: [SIZE, BUDGET, ALTERNATIVES, URGENCY]

Your pricing decision

What does this problem cost my customer per year, in money?

.....

What am I charging now, and what would a 30% increase look like?

.....

What is my new price for the next five prospects?

.....

YOUR ACTION STEPS

- ☐ Calculate what your customer's problem costs them annually. Write the number down.
- ☐ Raise your price by at least 25 percent for the next new customer. Do not explain or apologise.
- ☐ If you sell subscriptions, add an annual plan at a 15 to 20 percent discount this week.
- ☐ Identify one entry-level offer under \$50 you could create to feed your core product.

CHAPTER 9

Operations and Automation

Building the machine that runs when you do not

Every hour spent on work a system could do is an hour not spent on the work only you can do. Solo founders who implement automation properly report reclaiming fifteen to twenty hours a week — more than two full working days. This chapter is about how to get those hours without spending six months building infrastructure.

The four-way sort

Before automating anything, sort every recurring task into one of four categories. Most people skip straight to automation and end up building elaborate systems for work that should not exist at all.

Category	Test	Action
Eliminate	Would anything actually break if I simply stopped?	Stop. Start here — it is free and instant.
Automate	Is it repetitive with predictable inputs and clear rules?	Build it once with Zapier, Make, or n8n.
Delegate	Does it need human judgement but not specifically mine?	Contract it out by the project, not by the hour.
Do	Does it require my expertise, relationships, or taste?	Protect the time for this ruthlessly.

Eliminate before you automate

Roughly a third of what a new founder does every week produces nothing and exists because it feels like work: checking analytics multiple times a day, reorganising project boards, researching tools, redesigning things nobody has seen, reading business content instead of doing business. Automating these makes them permanent. Kill them instead.

The five automations that matter most

Customer onboarding

The moment someone pays, a sequence should fire without you: receipt and welcome email, access provisioned, getting-started resources delivered, a task created for anything manual, and a check-in scheduled for three days later. This is the highest-value automation because it runs at the exact moment a customer is deciding whether they made a good choice.

Typical stack: Stripe or Razorpay → Zapier → email platform + Notion + calendar

Customer support

An assistant trained on your documentation and past answers handles the routine seventy to eighty percent — pricing questions, how-to queries, account issues. Anything it cannot answer confidently escalates to you with the full conversation attached. The point is not to avoid customers; it is to avoid answering the same question for the ninetieth time.

Typical stack: Claude or GPT via Intercom, Crisp, or a custom agent

Content distribution

One piece of cornerstone content should propagate everywhere without further intervention: newsletter published, excerpt posted to LinkedIn, thread queued on X, transcript posted to your blog, clip scheduled for short-form video.

Typical stack: Beehiiv or Kit → Zapier → Postiz or Buffer → blog

Money

Invoices generated and sent on schedule, payment reminders escalating automatically, receipts issued, failed subscription payments retried and chased, revenue logged to your books. Chasing payment manually is both unpleasant and entirely unnecessary.

Typical stack: Stripe or Razorpay → Zapier → accounting tool + spreadsheet

Lead nurture

Someone joins your list and enters a sequence that educates them over several weeks and eventually presents an offer. Written once, it works for years, and it converts people who were not ready on the day they found you — which is most people.

Typical stack: Email platform sequences, triggered by signup source

AI agents: what they actually do well

An agent differs from an automation in that it makes decisions rather than following a fixed path, retains memory across runs, and can chain multiple steps toward a goal. The agent market reached roughly \$5.4 billion in 2024 and is projected to grow enormously, but the practical reality for a solo founder in 2026 is narrower than the marketing suggests.

What agents do reliably today: triaging and categorising inbound email, researching prospects and drafting personalised outreach for your review, monitoring competitors and sources for changes, summarising recurring reports, aggregating feedback across channels into weekly themes, and keeping records consistent between systems.

What they still do unreliably: anything requiring genuine judgement about your business, unsupervised customer-facing communication in sensitive situations, and multi-step tasks where an early mistake compounds silently. The correct posture is draft-and-review rather than fire-and-forget for anything a customer will see.

A caution on agent economics

Agents that call models frequently can become expensive quietly. A workflow that costs a few cents per run is trivial at ten runs a day and material at ten thousand. Set spending limits at the API level, monitor cost per outcome rather than cost per call, and check the bill weekly during the first month of any new agent.

Documenting your systems

Automation requires documentation, because you cannot automate a process you cannot describe. Documentation also does two other things for a solo operator: it makes delegation possible later, and it makes the business survivable if you are ill for three weeks. AI reduces the cost of producing documentation to almost nothing.

PROMPT — TURN A PROCESS INTO A DOCUMENTED SOP

Turn the following description into a clear standard operating procedure I can follow, hand to a contractor, or automate.

HERE IS HOW I CURRENTLY DO IT (rambling is fine):

[DESCRIBE THE PROCESS IN YOUR OWN WORDS]

Produce:

1. A numbered step-by-step procedure with clear decision points
2. The inputs required before starting and the definition of done
3. Common failure points and how to handle each
4. Which steps could be automated, and with which tool
5. Which steps genuinely require human judgement, and why

Then tell me: if I could only automate one step, which single step would save the most time, and how would I build it?

A realistic automation sequence

Do not attempt all of this at once. A workable order, roughly one item per week:

1. Payment received → receipt and welcome email sent automatically.
2. New subscriber → three-email welcome sequence.
3. FAQ document written and deployed as a support assistant.
4. Cornerstone content → automatic cross-posting to one other platform.
5. Invoice generation and payment chasing fully automated.
6. Weekly metrics compiled automatically into one summary you read on Friday.
7. Inbox triage agent drafting replies for your approval.

YOUR ACTION STEPS

- ☐ List every recurring task and sort each into eliminate, automate, delegate, or do.
- ☐ Eliminate at least two things this week. Do not replace them with anything.
- ☐ Build the payment-received automation — it takes under an hour and runs forever.
- ☐ Write your FAQ document with AI assistance and deploy it as a support assistant.
- ☐ Set a weekly recurring review of what you did more than twice.

PART IV

Reality

What it costs, what goes wrong, what actually happened
to the people who made it work.

10 · The Money Reality

11 · What Goes Wrong

12 · Six Founders, Six Paths

13 · Scaling Without Hiring

CHAPTER 10

The Money Reality

What this actually costs and what year one really looks like

Most business books skip this chapter because the numbers are less exciting than the success stories. But the founders who survive are usually the ones who understood their runway and their real costs before starting, rather than discovering them in month five.

What it costs to start

Genuinely less than almost any business in history. Here is a realistic first-year cost structure for each model, assuming you are frugal and use free tiers where they suffice.

Cost item	Service business	Digital product	Micro-SaaS
AI tools	\$20–40/mo	\$20–40/mo	\$40–60/mo
Automation	\$0–20/mo	\$20/mo	\$20/mo
Website / hosting	\$0–15/mo	\$0–15/mo	\$20–80/mo
Email platform	\$0–29/mo	\$0–49/mo	\$0–49/mo
Payments	~2–3% of revenue	~5–8% (platform + fees)	~3% of revenue
Product platform	—	\$0–39/mo	—
Domain	~\$12/yr	~\$12/yr	~\$12/yr
Realistic monthly total	\$40–100	\$60–150	\$100–250

The number that matters more than revenue

Your personal monthly expenses. Not a million dollars — the amount you actually need to live. For many readers that figure is between \$800 and \$3,000 a month. A business reaching that number has completely changed your life, and it is a far more achievable target than the headline figures in Chapter 1. Write your number down before you read further.

A realistic year one

The following is a composite based on typical outcomes for a service-first solo business run by someone working evenings and weekends initially. It is not a promise and it is not the fastest possible path — it is roughly what competent, consistent execution produces.

Period	Revenue	What is happening	Main risk
Months 1–2	\$0	Research, validation, first conversations, landing page	Quitting because nothing is happening
Month 3	\$500–2,000	First one or two clients, delivered manually	Underpricing to win the first client
Months 4–6	\$2,000–5,000/mo	Three to five clients, first systems, publishing begins	Delivery consuming all your time
Months 7–9	\$4,000–8,000/mo	Prices raised, processes documented, audience growing slowly	Burnout; no time to build anything scalable
Months 10–12	\$6,000–12,000/mo	First product launched, automation reducing delivery load	Splitting focus across too many things

Two honest caveats. Roughly half of people who start will not reach month three, almost entirely because the first two months produce no external validation and that is psychologically harder than it sounds. And the audience-first path looks materially worse than this in year one — often near zero revenue for eight to twelve months — before compounding sharply. Justin Welsh took twenty-nine months to reach \$1M cumulative; Dan Koe took roughly four years to go from \$10,000 a year to serious money. Neither was an overnight outcome.

Understanding your real margins

Headline margin figures in this space are genuinely high — 87 percent for Photo AI, reportedly around 98 percent for Dan Koe's media business — but they exclude the one input a solo founder should be costing: your own time. A more useful measure is effective hourly rate.

Scenario	Monthly revenue	Hours/month	Effective rate
Underpriced freelancing	\$3,000	160	\$19/hr
Properly priced service	\$8,000	100	\$80/hr
Productised service with AI delivery	\$12,000	80	\$150/hr
Mature product business	\$20,000	60	\$333/hr

The progression across those rows is not caused by working harder. It is caused by pricing correctly and by moving delivery work into systems. Track this number monthly — it is the single best indicator of whether your business is improving structurally or simply getting busier.

Tax and structure, in general terms

Specifics vary enormously by country and this book cannot give you advice for yours. Appendix C covers the situation for readers operating from India in detail. Four principles apply almost everywhere:

- **Separate your money immediately.** A dedicated business bank account from day one. Mixing personal and business funds creates accounting pain that compounds and can create legal exposure.
- **Set tax aside as revenue arrives, not at year end.** A common rule is to move 25 to 35 percent of every payment into a separate account and never touch it. Founders who skip this are the ones with a crisis in month fourteen.
- **Start simple, incorporate when there is a reason.** Sole proprietor or the local equivalent is usually adequate until you have meaningful revenue, real liability exposure, or a specific tax reason to change.
- **Keep every receipt from day one.** Tools, subscriptions, hardware, courses, internet, and workspace costs are typically deductible. This is real money and reconstructing it later is miserable.

Runway and the decision to go full time

The most common serious mistake in this whole domain is quitting a job too early. The romantic version — burning the boats — makes for good stories and bad outcomes, because desperation produces poor decisions: underpricing, accepting bad clients, chasing quick money instead of building anything durable.

A defensible rule for going full time

Three consecutive months where business revenue covers your essential personal expenses, plus six months of those expenses saved in cash. Meet both conditions and the transition is a calculated step. Meet neither and you are gambling. Meet one, and wait — the business will still be there in three months, and it will be stronger for having been built without panic.

Your money baseline

My essential monthly personal expenses:

.....

Monthly business revenue needed to cover that:

.....

Current savings, expressed in months of expenses:

.....

Target date to reach the three-month revenue test:

.....

YOUR ACTION STEPS

- ☐ Calculate your essential monthly expenses precisely. This is your real target.
- ☐ Open a separate business bank account this week if you have not already.
- ☐ Set up an automatic transfer of 30 percent of every payment received into a tax account.
- ☐ Calculate your current effective hourly rate. Recalculate it monthly.

CHAPTER 11

What Goes Wrong

The failure modes, and how to recognise yours early

This is the chapter that would be left out of a book designed to sell you something. Everything below is common, most of it is recoverable, and recognising which one you are in is usually the difference between a correction and an ending.

Failure mode 1 — Building for months without selling anything

What it looks like. Four months in, the product is nearly ready. You have refined the onboarding, rebuilt the landing page twice, and added a feature you thought of in the shower. You have spoken to no customers. It feels productive, because building is genuinely enjoyable and selling is genuinely uncomfortable.

Why it happens. Building is entirely within your control and provides constant small rewards. Selling involves rejection from strangers. The brain reliably chooses the first, and dresses the choice up as diligence.

The fix. Impose an external forcing function. Set a date, tell someone, and sell before the product is finished — take pre-orders, run a paid pilot, deliver the first version manually. If the thought of showing it to someone makes you want to refine it further, that is precisely the signal to show it today.

Failure mode 2 — The niche that never had money in it

What it looks like. People say they love the idea. Engagement is fine. Nobody buys. You conclude the problem is your marketing and spend three months improving copy that was never the issue.

Why it happens. Enthusiasm is free to give and costs nothing to withdraw. The validation in Chapter 3 was skipped or done with weak signals — surveys and waitlists rather than payments.

The fix. Ask directly for money, early, from fifteen qualified people. If none buy, the niche or the offer is wrong, and no amount of marketing improvement will change that. Change the offer first, since it is cheaper; change the niche if the second offer also fails.

Failure mode 3 — The delivery trap

What it looks like. Revenue is decent — \$6,000 or \$8,000 a month — and you have no time at all. Every hour goes to client delivery. You have not published in six weeks, built nothing scalable, and the pipeline is empty because you have had no time for sales. When a client leaves, revenue drops immediately and you scramble.

Why it happens. Service revenue arrives quickly and feels like success, which obscures the fact that it does not compound. Every month starts at zero.

The fix. Raise prices and reduce client count — this is almost always the correct first move and it is counterintuitive enough that most people resist it. Then protect one full day a week for non-delivery work before you feel you can afford to. You will never feel you can afford to.

Failure mode 4 — Quitting during the flat period

What it looks like. Months three to eight of an audience-led business. You are publishing consistently, the numbers barely move, and the effort-to-visible-result ratio is demoralising. You conclude it does not work for you and stop.

Why it happens. Compounding is invisible until it is not, and the flat part of the curve is much longer than anyone expects. Every founder profiled in this book went through this period; you simply do not read about it because nobody writes retrospectives about the boring middle.

The fix. Commit in advance to a fixed period — ninety days minimum, ideally six months — and measure inputs rather than outputs during it. Did you publish? That is the metric. Audience size is not under your control on any given week; publishing is.

Failure mode 5 — Tool and strategy churn

What it looks like. You have switched email platforms twice, restarted your newsletter, changed your positioning three times, and are researching a new automation tool. Each change felt justified. Cumulatively, nothing has been given long enough to work.

Why it happens. Switching provides the feeling of progress without the discomfort of exposure. It is procrastination with a professional-looking surface.

The fix. A standing rule: no changes to tools, positioning, or channel for ninety days once chosen, except in response to direct customer evidence. Write the rule down. Revisit only at the ninety-day mark.

Failure mode 6 — Burnout and the single point of failure

What it looks like. You have not had a genuine week off in a year. Customer support follows you on holiday. A period of illness costs real revenue. The freedom the business was supposed to provide has become a form of confinement.

Why it happens. Structurally, you are the single point of failure, and unlike a company with staff there is no redundancy anywhere in the system.

The fix. This is the one that requires deliberate design rather than willpower. Document your processes so a contractor could cover for two weeks. Build the support automation before you need it. Take a scheduled week off every quarter, announced to customers in advance — almost nobody minds, and the assumption that they will is usually projection.

The diagnostic question

When something is not working, ask: am I avoiding a specific uncomfortable action? The honest answer identifies the failure mode almost every time. Building instead of selling, researching instead of publishing, switching tools instead of asking for money — the shape is always the same. The uncomfortable action is nearly always the correct next step.

Signals worth taking seriously

Signal	What it usually means	Reasonable response
20 conversations, nobody names the problem unprompted	The problem is not urgent	Change the niche
People engage but never buy	The offer or the price is wrong	Change the offer before the niche
90 days of publishing, zero organic response	Wrong channel or wrong message	Change one variable, not both
Revenue is fine but you dread the work	Wrong client type or wrong model	Raise prices; fire the worst client
Growing but perpetually out of time	Delivery trap	Systematise or productise now

YOUR ACTION STEPS

- ☐ Identify which failure mode most resembles your current situation. Be honest.
- ☐ Name the specific uncomfortable action you have been avoiding. Do it within 48 hours.
- ☐ Write your ninety-day no-change rule and put it somewhere visible.
- ☐ Schedule one week off in the next quarter, now, before you have a reason not to.

CHAPTER 12

Six Founders, Six Paths

What they actually did, including the slow parts

Case studies are useful only when they include the timeline. Every story below is presented with how long it took, because the compression of these narratives into "built a business, sold it for millions" is the single most misleading thing about how they are usually told.

BASE44 — \$80M ACQUISITION IN ABOUT 16 MONTHS

Maor Shlomo

Israeli developer, thirty-one, starting a side project after military service in late 2024. Base44 let non-technical people build software by describing it in plain English. He incorporated in January 2025, shipped as many as thirteen production updates a day, monitored servers every two to three hours, and got feedback from friends rather than running marketing. Growth was word of mouth. By May 2025 he was making around \$189,000 monthly profit; by June, 300,000 users and roughly \$3.5M ARR. Wix acquired the company for \$80 million in cash. Total personal investment: approximately \$10,000 to \$20,000.

Lesson: Ship faster than feels comfortable, and make the product good enough that users share it without being asked.

The uncomfortable detail: he was effectively on call around the clock during the growth period. This was not a lifestyle business.

PHOTO AI — ~\$132K MRR, 87%+ NET MARGIN

Pieter Levels

Probably the most influential indie hacker of the last decade, with more than seventy launched projects behind him — the overwhelming majority of which went nowhere. Photo AI generates professional portraits using AI models and reached roughly \$132,000 in monthly recurring revenue with net margins above 87 percent and no employees. His method is consistent across everything he builds: launch fast, charge from day one, automate aggressively, build in public, and treat most projects as disposable experiments.

Lesson: Volume of attempts matters more than quality of any single attempt. Charge from the first day.

The uncomfortable detail: the seventy failed projects are the actual story. Survivorship bias is the whole lesson here.

COURSES AND NEWSLETTER — \$10M+ CUMULATIVE

Justin Welsh

Burned out after years leading SaaS sales teams. Began publishing on LinkedIn in 2019, building slowly and systematically: daily posts, a weekly newsletter, then courses teaching the system he had developed. It took twenty-nine months to reach \$1 million in cumulative revenue — not months, twenty-nine months. By 2025 he had passed \$10 million cumulative, with no full-time employees and no paid advertising at any point.

Lesson: Consistency over a long period beats intensity over a short one. Build the audience before the product.

The uncomfortable detail: nearly two and a half years of daily publishing before the first million. Most people quit in month four.

MISS EXCEL — \$2.9M/YEAR

Kat Norton

Working in corporate finance in 2020 when she began posting Excel tutorials on TikTok — energetic, funny, and genuinely useful. The audience grew rapidly, she left her job, and converted the following into online courses. By 2024 the business was generating approximately \$2.9 million annually, bootstrapped, with Norton as the sole operator for the period in which it first crossed a million in course sales.

Lesson: The niche does not need to be exciting. Execution and personality carry more weight than subject matter.

The uncomfortable detail: the format was suited to her specifically. Copying the format without the personality does not reproduce the result.

POSTIZ — \$145K MRR, GROWING ~\$1K MRR/DAY

Nevo David

Built a social media scheduling platform as a solo founder, reaching approximately \$145,000 in monthly recurring revenue — about \$1.74 million annualised — and growing by roughly \$1,000 MRR daily. He built it using AI coding tools, marketed through build-in-public content on X and LinkedIn, and grew through word of mouth and organic search rather than paid acquisition. The product publishes across more than thirty channels from a single workflow.

Lesson: Solve a bottleneck you personally experience in a workflow you personally use. Then talk about it publicly, continuously.

The uncomfortable detail: this is a crowded category with well-funded competitors. He won on focus and founder-led distribution, not on being first.

NONPROFIT AI CONSULTING PLATFORM — HUNDREDS OF CLIENTS

Dana Snyder

The most instructive story here for non-technical readers. Snyder identified that nonprofits could not afford human consultants for fundraising strategy, and built an AI-powered platform to serve them. She had no technical background whatsoever. She built it over roughly six months using Replit's AI coding tools. The platform now automates monthly giving programme development, fundraising strategy, and donor communications for hundreds of clients, and she remains the only full-time employee.

Lesson: Domain expertise plus AI building tools beats technical skill without domain expertise.

You already know something worth building around.

The uncomfortable detail: six months of building while learning the tools. "No code required" does not mean "no effort required".

The patterns across all six

Six very different businesses, but the commonalities are striking and worth stating plainly:

- **Every one of them published in public throughout.** Not one built quietly and launched to silence.
- **Every one started from something they already knew or personally needed.** None entered a market cold to chase an opportunity.
- **Every one charged money early.** None waited for the product to be finished before finding out whether anyone would pay.
- **Every one took longer than the summary suggests.** The shortest was sixteen months; the longest were measured in years.
- **None raised outside investment.** Not one.

Read these correctly

These six people are the visible tail of an enormous distribution. Pieter Levels has seventy failed projects behind Photo AI, and the others have their own unpublished failures. The correct reading of this chapter is not "this is what will happen to me". It is "the ceiling is much higher than I assumed, and every one of them started with something they already knew".

CHAPTER 13

Scaling Without Hiring

Growing revenue while keeping headcount at one

The conventional path is to raise money and hire. The solo path is to grow revenue and freedom while keeping the team at one. This is not smallness for its own sake — it is a deliberate choice to grow through leverage rather than through headcount, and it requires different moves at each stage.

The transition problem

The activities that take you from zero to \$10,000 a month are almost entirely different from those that take you from \$10,000 to \$50,000. The first phase rewards hustle, personal outreach, and hand-crafted delivery. The second rewards systems, productisation, and saying no. Most founders stall precisely because they keep doing what worked, past the point where it works.

Stage	What the work is	What kills you here	The unlock
\$0–\$1K/mo	Conversations and first sales	No external validation; self-doubt	One paying customer
\$1K–\$5K/mo	Repeatability and retention	Inconsistency; ad-hoc delivery	A documented process
\$5K–\$20K/mo	Systems and distribution	Delivery consuming all your time	Price increase + automation
\$20K–\$50K/mo	Productisation and leverage	Decision fatigue; quality drift	A second revenue stream
\$50K+/mo	Compounding assets	Your own capacity ceiling	Contractors and agents

The five levers

Lever 1 — Productise

Convert bespoke work into a defined package with a fixed scope, price, and process. The client gets the same outcome with less uncertainty; you get predictable delivery that can be systematised and eventually partially automated. This single move typically improves effective hourly rate more than anything else available to you.

Lever 2 — Create assets that sell without you

Courses, templates, playbooks, tools. Built once, sold indefinitely. The important property is not passivity — nothing is truly passive — but that revenue stops being strictly proportional to hours worked.

Lever 3 — Own your distribution

A newsletter of ten thousand engaged readers, or twenty pages ranking for high-intent search terms, generates customers without daily effort. This is the closest thing to an appreciating asset a solo business can hold, and it is the reason audience-first founders eventually overtake service-first ones.

Lever 4 — Use contractors deliberately

Solo does not have to mean alone forever. Project-based specialists — a video editor for four hours weekly, a developer for one specific feature, an accountant quarterly — add capacity without the fixed cost, management overhead, or commitment of employment. Global platforms such as Upwork, Toptal, and Deel make this practical.

Lever 5 — Expand capacity with AI

As models improve, your effective output grows without additional hours. The discipline is to reinvest reclaimed time into higher-leverage work rather than absorbing it into more of the same. Audit your stack quarterly and ask what has become possible that was not six months ago.

What to do when you hit your ceiling

Every solo founder eventually reaches a point where more revenue genuinely requires more capacity than one person has. There are four honest options, and choosing deliberately beats drifting into whichever happens.

Option	What it means	Best when
Stay at the ceiling	Optimise for margin and time, not growth	The income is sufficient and you value the freedom
Productise harder	Convert remaining bespoke work into products	Demand exceeds delivery capacity
Add contractors	Keep ownership, add capacity project by project	One specific function is the bottleneck
Sell the business	Exit and start again with capital and experience	Revenue is stable, recurring, and documented

Staying small is a legitimate strategy

A business generating \$15,000 a month with twenty hours of work a week, no employees, and no investors is an extraordinary outcome by any reasonable standard. The pressure to grow indefinitely comes largely from a venture-capital narrative that does not apply to you and was never designed for your situation. Decide what you actually want before optimising for someone else's definition of success.

YOUR ACTION STEPS

- ☐ Identify which revenue stage you are in and what the table says kills founders there.
- ☐ Name your single biggest time bottleneck and design one system to halve it in thirty days.
- ☐ List every piece of expertise you hold. Mark the ones that could become sellable assets.
- ☐ Decide now what "enough" looks like for you, in revenue and in hours per week.

PART V

Execution

One business followed end to end, and the ninety days
that start yours.

14 · A Complete Worked Example

15 · Your 90-Day Plan

CHAPTER 14

A Complete Worked Example

From an idea to \$8,000 a month, decision by decision

Everything in this book is easier to understand applied than described. What follows is a single business followed from nothing to a working operation, with the reasoning shown at each step. The business is composite and illustrative — assembled from patterns that repeat across real solo businesses — but every decision in it is one you will face.

Meet Priya

Priya spent six years as an operations manager at a mid-sized logistics company. She is not a developer. She has no audience. She has about ten hours a week outside her job and roughly \$500 she is willing to spend. She wants to replace \$4,000 a month of income within a year. This is a realistic starting position and closely resembles most readers of this book.

Week 1 — Finding the niche

Priya starts where Chapter 3 says to start: her own experience. Her list of paid skills includes vendor management, shipment tracking, warehouse process design, and — the one she almost leaves off because it feels mundane — building the spreadsheet systems that kept her operations team functioning.

She runs the niche generation prompt and gets twenty candidates. Most are too broad. Three survive: freight brokers drowning in manual quote tracking, small e-commerce operations with no inventory forecasting, and third-party logistics providers who report to clients manually every week.

She scores them on the eight-criterion scorecard. The third-party logistics option scores highest — she knows exactly who these people are, she has been their customer, she knows the reporting problem intimately because she used to receive the reports, and she knows they have budgets.

Criterion	3PL reporting	Freight quotes	E-com forecasting
Problem urgency	5 — weekly, unavoidable	4	3
Willingness to pay	5 — they bill clients for it	4	2
Her credibility	5 — was the client	3	2
Reachability	4 — LinkedIn, trade groups	4	3
Market size	3 — thousands, not millions	4	5
Competition	4 — generic BI tools only	2	2
Solo feasibility	5 — she can do this alone	3	3
Genuine interest	4	3	2
TOTAL	35 / 40	27 / 40	22 / 40

Week 2 — Validation, and a surprise

Priya messages twenty-two people on LinkedIn who work at small third-party logistics firms. She does not pitch. The message asks a single question: how do you currently put together the weekly client reports, and how long does it take?

Nine reply. Six agree to a fifteen-minute call. What she learns changes the business. The reporting itself is not the pain — the pain is that reports are assembled by copying data from three separate systems into a spreadsheet, every single week, by someone whose time is expensive, and errors in that copying are what generate angry client emails.

The validation lesson

Priya went in believing the problem was "reports take too long". The real problem was "manual data assembly produces errors that damage client relationships". Those sound similar and are not. The second is urgent, emotionally charged, and has a clear cost. This distinction is only ever discovered by talking to people, and it is why validation cannot be skipped.

She asks each of the six what they would pay for a weekly report that was assembled accurately without their team touching it. Answers range from \$300 to \$1,200 a month. Two say they would start immediately.

Week 3 — Choosing the model

The instinct is to build software. Priya cannot build software, and building it would take six months during which she would earn nothing and learn little. Chapter 5 says the productised service is the correct starting point for exactly this situation.

Her offer: a fixed weekly client-reporting package. She collects the data exports, assembles and checks the report using AI-assisted workflows, and delivers a finished, branded report their account manager can send without editing. Price: \$600 a month per client. Delivery: manual at first, with a target of three hours per client per month.

Decision	What she chose	Why
Model	Productised service	Revenue in weeks, no build risk, learns the domain deeply
Price	\$600/month	Mid-range of what they said; leaves room to raise
Delivery	Manual, AI-assisted	Proves the workflow before automating it
Channel	LinkedIn + direct outreach	Her buyers are demonstrably there
Scope	One report type only	Refuses all custom requests in month one

Weeks 4–6 — First revenue

The two interested prospects become her first clients at \$600 each. She sets a deliberate rule: she will not build anything, automate anything, or design a logo until she has delivered four full weeks manually. She wants to know exactly where the work is before she systematises it.

The first month is ugly. Delivery takes eleven hours per client, not three. She learns that each client exports data in a different format, that two of the three systems produce inconsistent date fields, and that the actual value she adds is spotting anomalies the client's own team had been missing for months.

That last discovery becomes the centre of her positioning. She is not producing reports. She is catching problems before clients do.

Weeks 7–12 — Systems and price

With four weeks of manual delivery behind her, Priya knows exactly what to automate. She builds three things, in this order:

1. A cleaning and normalisation workflow that takes any of the three export formats and produces one consistent structure. Built in a spreadsheet with AI-generated formulas — no code.

2. A prompt library that turns the normalised data into the written commentary section of the report, in her voice, with anomalies flagged for her review.
3. An onboarding automation: a new client signs, and a folder structure, a data-request email, and a recurring task sequence are created automatically.

Delivery time falls from eleven hours to about four. She raises the price for new clients to \$850, quoting it without explanation. The next three prospects all accept.

Month 3	\$1,200	11 → 4 hrs	\$600 → \$850
first two clients	monthly revenue at month 3	delivery time per client	price after systemisation

Months 4–8 — Distribution

Priya starts publishing on LinkedIn twice a week. She does not write about her service. She writes about the operational problems she keeps encountering: the three reconciliation errors that appear in almost every logistics dataset, why weekly reporting breaks down at a certain company size, what she found in a client's data that had been wrong for a year.

This is the content engine from Chapter 7 applied literally. Each week she writes one substantial post from something that happened during delivery, then extracts three shorter pieces from it. Two hours a week total.

The results are unremarkable for two months and then compound. By month six she is receiving one or two inbound enquiries a week from people who recognised their own problem in her writing. Her close rate on inbound is roughly four times her cold outreach rate, and the conversations are shorter because trust already exists.

Months 9–12 — Stacking the second stream

By month nine Priya has nine clients at an average of \$850 — about \$7,650 a month — and she is at capacity. Chapter 13 says this is the delivery trap, and the correct moves are to raise prices and to productise. She does both.

She raises new-client pricing to \$1,200 and stops accepting clients below that. She loses two prospects and keeps her margin. More significantly, she packages what she has learned into a self-serve product: a template system with the normalisation workflow, the prompt library, and a written playbook, sold at \$340 to the operations managers who follow her on LinkedIn but cannot afford the service.

Month 12 position	Figure
Service clients	8 (having pruned two low-value ones)
Service revenue	~\$7,800/month
Product sales	~12/month at \$340 = ~\$4,080
Total monthly revenue	~\$11,880
Hours worked per week	~28
Effective hourly rate	~\$106
Employees	0
Outside investment	\$0

What actually mattered

- **She started from what she already knew.** The domain expertise was the entire advantage; the AI tools were leverage applied on top of it.
- **She talked to twenty-two people before building anything.** The conversation in week two redefined the business.
- **She delivered manually for a month before automating.** Every system she built afterwards was aimed at a bottleneck she had personally experienced.
- **She raised prices twice.** Revenue roughly doubled without doubling the client count or the work.
- **She published from the work.** The content cost two hours a week because the raw material was generated by delivery anyway.
- **She stacked the product only after the service was stable.** Not in month two, when it would have split her focus and failed.

The uncomfortable parts, stated plainly

Months one and two produced no revenue at all. Month four involved eleven-hour delivery weeks alongside a full-time job. Two clients left. Her first three months of LinkedIn posting produced almost no response. None of this appears in a summary of the outcome, and all of it is the actual work.

CHAPTER 15

Your 90-Day Plan

Specific, dated, and starting this week

Everything in this book reduces to a sequence of actions. This chapter is that sequence, organised into thirteen weeks. It assumes ten to fifteen hours a week, which is what most people have alongside existing commitments.

Month 1 — Decide and validate

Week 1 · Choose your ground

- List your roles, paid skills, deep knowledge, and self-solved problems.
- Run the niche generation prompt. Produce twenty candidates, narrow to five.
- Score your top three on the eight-criterion scorecard.
- Commit to one. Write down why, and the date you committed.

Week 2 · Listen

- Find three places your audience gathers. Read for two hours. Copy fifty verbatim complaints.
- Message twenty people with a single question about the problem. Do not pitch.
- Hold at least five conversations. Take written notes.
- Write down the problem in their words, not yours.

Week 3 · Define the offer

- Choose your business model using Chapter 5. One model only.
- Define the offer: specific outcome, timeline, price. Use the pricing prompt.
- Build a one-page landing page describing the outcome. Add an email field.
- Set up payment collection. See Appendix C if you are operating from India.

Week 4 · Ask for money

- Return to everyone you spoke to in week two with a specific offer.
- Send fifteen personalised outreach messages using the outreach prompt.
- Target: one paying customer, even at a reduced founding rate.
- If nobody buys, change the offer before changing the niche.

The month one test

At the end of thirty days you should have: a chosen niche you can defend, notes from at least five real conversations, a defined offer with a price, a live page, and either a paying customer or clear evidence about why not. If you have a beautiful brand, a logo, and no conversations, you have spent the month avoiding the work.

Month 2 — Deliver and systematise

Weeks 5–6 · Deliver manually

- Deliver the outcome by hand. Do not automate anything yet.
- Track exactly where your hours go, in writing.
- Ask your first customer what nearly stopped them from buying.
- Get a second customer at full price.

Week 7 · Build your first systems

- Document your delivery process using the SOP prompt.
- Build the payment-received automation.
- Build one delivery automation aimed at your largest time sink.
- Set up your standing context prompt and start a prompt library.

Week 8 · Start publishing

- Choose one channel. Write the ninety-day evaluation date in your calendar.
- Publish your first cornerstone piece, drawn from delivery experience.
- Extract short-form content using the extraction prompt.
- Set up scheduling so publishing does not depend on daily willpower.

Month 3 — Grow and stabilise

Weeks 9–10 · Sell consistently

- Fifteen outreach messages per week, every week.
- Publish one cornerstone piece per week without exception.
- Target: three to five paying customers total.
- Raise your price for new customers by 25 percent.

Week 11 · Reduce the delivery load

- Identify your largest remaining manual step. Automate or template it.

- Deploy an FAQ-trained support assistant.
- Write your three decision rules: minimum price, ideal client, automatic decline.

Week 12 · Review honestly

- Calculate revenue, hours worked, and effective hourly rate.
- Identify which failure mode from Chapter 11 you are closest to.
- Decide what to stop doing. Something should be stopped.

Week 13 · Plan the next ninety days

- Choose the one metric that matters most for the next quarter.
- Decide which second revenue stream to stack, and what must be true first.
- Schedule a week off in the coming quarter. Now, in the calendar.

The realistic outcome

At the end of ninety days, executed properly, you should expect somewhere between \$1,000 and \$5,000 in monthly revenue, three to six customers, a documented delivery process, one working automation, and roughly twelve pieces of published content. That is not a business that has replaced your income. It is a business that has proven it can exist, which is the only thing ninety days can honestly prove.

It is also, statistically, further than the overwhelming majority of people who read a book like this will get — not because they lack ability, but because they will read it and do nothing.

Commit in writing

My niche (the specific person and their problem):

.....

My offer and price:

.....

My channel:

.....

Date I will collect my first payment:

.....

The person I am telling about this commitment:

.....

A closing word

The hard part of this was never the tools. The tools are cheap, capable, and getting better every month. The hard part is the day in month four when nobody has bought anything, your publishing has produced silence, and the sensible-sounding voice suggests that this was always unlikely and you should stop.

Every founder in Chapter 12 had that day. Levels had it seventy times. Welsh had it for the better part of two years before the first million. The only thing separating the people who make it from the people who do not is that the first group kept going through a period that felt exactly like failure and was actually just the middle.

*"The one-person startup with AI is not a dream. It is a decision,
followed by about four hundred small actions."*

— The end of this book, and the start of the work

Start today

Not tomorrow, not when you feel ready, not when the idea is perfect. Today. Write down your niche candidate. Send one message to one person in it. Tell someone what you are building. The first action is the only one that is genuinely difficult; after that, momentum does most of the work.

*Thank you for reading.
Now close the book and go and talk to somebody about their problem.*

Dilip Saroj · dilipsaroj95@gmail.com · 2026

PART VI

Appendices

Reference material you will come back to.

- A · The Prompt Library
 - B · Templates and Frameworks
 - C · Operating From India
 - D · Tools and Communities
-

APPENDIX A

The Prompt Library

Twenty prompts, organised by what you are trying to do

These are written to be copied directly into Claude, ChatGPT, or any capable assistant. Replace anything in [SQUARE BRACKETS]. The prompts marked with a dagger also appear in the relevant chapter; the rest are new. Save the ones you use into your own library and edit them until they sound like you.

Two rules that make every prompt below work better

- Always establish context first — paste your standing context prompt (A1) at the start of a session.
- Always ask for critique of the output before accepting it. "What is weakest about this?" costs nothing.

A · Setup and thinking

PROMPT — A1 — STANDING CONTEXT +

I am going to work with you regularly. Keep this in mind throughout.

BUSINESS: [what you sell, to whom]

AUDIENCE: [the specific person, situation, and problem]

MY VOICE: [direct/warm/technical – plus 2 sentences I would write
and 1 phrase I would never write]

GOAL THIS QUARTER: [one measurable objective]

CONSTRAINTS: [hours available, budget, skills I lack]

When I ask for writing, match my voice, not a generic professional register. When I ask for advice, prioritise what I can execute alone this week. If a request rests on a bad assumption, say so before answering.

PROMPT — A2 — PRESSURE-TEST A DECISION +

I am considering: [DECISION AND MY REASONING]

Do not tell me it is a good idea. Instead:

1. The three strongest arguments against it
2. Assumptions I am making but have not stated
3. The most likely way this fails within 90 days
4. Evidence I could gather this week that would change my mind

Be direct. I would rather be corrected now than in six months.

PROMPT — A3 — WEEKLY REVIEW

Here is what I did this week: [BULLET LIST]

Here are my numbers: [REVENUE, CUSTOMERS, PUBLISHED, ENQUIRIES]

My goal this quarter is: [GOAL]

1. Which of these activities actually moved me toward the goal?
2. Which were motion without progress? Be blunt.
3. What is the single highest-leverage thing I could do next week?
4. What should I stop doing entirely?

Do not be encouraging. Be useful.

B · Niche and validation

PROMPT — A4 — GENERATE NICHE CANDIDATES +

Here is my background:

Work experience: [ROLES AND YEARS]

Skills I have been paid for: [LIST]

Things I know unusually well: [LIST]

Problems I have solved for myself: [LIST]

Generate 20 specific niche opportunities where my background gives me credibility. For each: the specific person (role and situation, not a demographic), their painful problem, evidence people already pay to solve it, and why I am credible to them.

"Small business owners" is not a person. "Solo dental practice owners handling their own billing" is.

PROMPT — A5 — ANALYSE COMMUNITY PAIN POINTS +

Below are real posts from [COMMUNITY], where [AUDIENCE] gather.

1. The five most frequent frustrations, ranked
2. The exact phrases they use for each
3. Which ones cost them money or significant time
4. What they have tried and why it failed
5. Any recurring problem with no obvious existing solution

Quote their actual language. Do not translate into marketing speak.

POSTS:

[PASTE 30-50 POSTS]

PROMPT — A6 — DESIGN A VALIDATION TEST

My hypothesis: [SPECIFIC AUDIENCE] will pay [PRICE] for [OUTCOME] because [REASON].

Design the cheapest possible test of this that produces a real signal, not a polite one. Specify:

- Exactly what I do, in order
- What I say, word for word
- How many people I need to reach
- What result would confirm the hypothesis
- What result should make me abandon it

The test must involve asking for money or a commitment, not a survey. It must be completable in under 7 days.

PROMPT — A7 — COMPETITOR GAP ANALYSIS

My market: [NICHE]. Main competitors: [LIST 3-5].

Below are reviews and comments about them: [PASTE REVIEWS, especially 2- and 3-star ones]

1. Who is each competitor clearly built for?
2. Who is buying despite not being that person, and what are they compromising on?
3. Which complaints appear repeatedly across competitors?
4. Where is there an underserved segment I could serve better as a one-person business?
5. What could I honestly claim that none of them can?

C · Building and product

PROMPT — A8 — CUT YOUR SCOPE +

I am building v1 of [PRODUCT] for [USER].

Core outcome: [OUTCOME].

Planned features: [LIST EVERYTHING]

Act as a ruthless PM whose only goal is shipping in 7 days.

Mark each feature KEEP (required for the core outcome), FAKE (can be done manually behind the scenes), or CUT (not needed before 100 users).

Then describe the smallest version that still delivers the outcome. Be aggressive.

PROMPT — A9 — TURN FEEDBACK INTO A PRIORITY LIST

Here is feedback from my first users: [PASTE EVERYTHING]

1. Group these into themes
2. Separate "this blocks me from getting value" from "this would be nice"
3. Identify anything that suggests I have misunderstood the problem itself
4. Rank the top 5 changes by impact on whether someone would recommend this unprompted
5. Tell me what to ignore and why

PROMPT — A10 — WRITE ONBOARDING THAT WORKS

Product: [WHAT IT DOES]. User: [WHO]. Core outcome: [OUTCOME].

The first useful thing they should experience: [MOMENT]

Write the onboarding sequence that gets a new user to that moment as fast as possible:

- The welcome email (short, one action)
- The first 3 in-product steps
- A 3-day check-in email

Assume they are busy and sceptical. No feature tours.

D · Marketing and content

PROMPT — A11 — EXTRACT A WEEK OF CONTENT +

Below is a long-form piece I wrote.

AUDIENCE: [SPECIFIC PERSON]

MY VOICE: [DESCRIPTION + 2 SAMPLE SENTENCES]

Produce: 3 LinkedIn posts (150-250 words, one idea each),
2 X threads (5-7 posts, strong first line), 1 short-video
script (45 seconds, hook in 3 seconds).

Each must stand alone. Use my phrasing, not generic LinkedIn
voice. No "Here is the thing:", no "Let that sink in", no
engagement bait.

SOURCE:

[PASTE]

PROMPT — A12 — COLD OUTREACH +

I offer: [SERVICE AND OUTCOME]

Recipient: [ROLE] at [COMPANY]

Specific thing I noticed: [REAL OBSERVATION]

Proof I can do this: [RESULT OR EXPERIENCE]

Under 120 words. Open with the observation, not with me. One
quantified outcome. Ask for a reply, not a call. No flattery,
no "hope this finds you well", no fake urgency.

PROMPT — A13 — LANDING PAGE COPY

Product/service: [WHAT]. For: [SPECIFIC PERSON].

The problem in their words: [FROM YOUR RESEARCH – verbatim]

What happens if they do nothing: [COST]

Proof: [RESULTS, TESTIMONIALS, EXPERIENCE]

Price: [PRICE]

Write: a headline stating the outcome, a subheadline naming the person, three short problem-agitation paragraphs in their language, what they get (outcomes not features), proof, price with justification, and one call to action.

No jargon. No "revolutionary", "seamless", "game-changing".

Write like someone explaining it to a colleague.

PROMPT — A14 — CONTENT IDEAS FROM DELIVERY WORK

This week in my business I: [WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENED – problems solved, mistakes made, things learned, client questions]

My audience is: [SPECIFIC PERSON]

Give me 10 content ideas drawn from this. For each: the angle, the specific insight, and why my audience would care. Prioritise things that are useful even to someone who never hires me.

Avoid generic advice. The value is in the specificity.

PROMPT — A15 — SEO ARTICLE BRIEF

Target query: [LONG-TAIL SEARCH TERM]

Searcher intent: [WHAT THEY ACTUALLY WANT]

My angle: [MY EXPERIENCE OR DATA]

Produce a brief, not the article:

- The specific question the page must answer in the first 100 words
- A section outline with the sub-question each section answers
- What existing top-ranking pages get wrong or leave out
- Where my first-hand experience should go
- Related queries to cover on the same page

I will write the substance myself.

E · Pricing, sales and operations

PROMPT — A16 — BUILD THE VALUE CASE †

I provide [SERVICE] to [CUSTOMER].

1. What does this problem cost them if unsolved? Consider wasted hours, lost revenue, cost of wrong decisions, and what they currently spend on alternatives.
2. Quantify per month and per year, stating assumptions.
3. What is a defensible price range?
4. Three sentences I can say aloud justifying the top of that range, framed around their outcome.
5. The three likeliest objections and honest answers.

Customer context: [SIZE, BUDGET, ALTERNATIVES, URGENCY]

PROMPT — A17 — HANDLE AN OBJECTION

A prospect said: "[EXACT OBJECTION]"

Context: [WHAT I OFFER, PRICE, WHERE WE ARE IN THE CONVERSATION]

1. What are they most likely actually concerned about?
2. Is this a real objection or a polite no? How can I tell?
3. An honest response that does not pressure them
4. One question I could ask to understand the real concern

Do not give me manipulative sales tactics. If they should not buy, tell me that.

PROMPT — A18 — DOCUMENT A PROCESS AS AN SOP +

Here is how I currently do this (rambling is fine):

[DESCRIBE THE PROCESS]

Produce:

1. Numbered steps with decision points
2. Required inputs and the definition of done
3. Common failure points and how to handle each
4. Which steps could be automated, with which tool
5. Which genuinely require human judgement, and why

Then: if I could automate only one step, which saves the most time and how would I build it?

PROMPT — A19 — DESIGN AN AUTOMATION

I want to automate: [DESCRIBE THE WORKFLOW]

Tools I already pay for: [LIST]

Technical ability: [NONE / SOME / COMFORTABLE]

Design the automation:

- The trigger
- Each step, in order, with the tool that performs it
- What data moves between steps
- Failure points and how to handle them
- Roughly how long it takes to build

Prefer tools I already have. Tell me if this is not worth automating yet, and what volume would make it worth it.

PROMPT — A20 — DRAFT A CUSTOMER SUPPORT ANSWER

Customer wrote: "[THEIR MESSAGE]"

Context: [WHAT THEY BOUGHT, HOW LONG AGO, ANY HISTORY]

The actual situation: [WHAT IS TRUE, INCLUDING IF I WAS WRONG]

Draft a reply that is honest, brief, and solves the problem.

If I made a mistake, acknowledge it plainly without excessive apology. Offer a specific next step. Match my voice: [VOICE].

No corporate language. No "we sincerely apologise for any inconvenience caused".

APPENDIX B

Templates and Frameworks

Fill these in rather than reading them

B1 • The niche scorecard

Score each criterion 1–5. Under 24 is likely painful; over 32 is worth committing to.

#	Criterion	Score 1	Score 5	Yours
1	Problem urgency	Mild annoyance	Costs them weekly	___
2	Willingness to pay	No precedent	Already paying	___
3	Your credibility	Complete outsider	Real experience	___
4	Reachability	Scattered	Concentrated	___
5	Market size	Under 500	Tens of thousands	___
6	Competition	Dominated by giants	Weak incumbents	___
7	Solo feasibility	Needs a team	You alone with AI	___
8	Genuine interest	Bored in a month	Five-year interest	___
TOTAL				___/40

B2 · The one-sentence positioning statement

Complete this until it stops sounding generic

I help [VERY SPECIFIC PERSON IN A SPECIFIC SITUATION]

.....
to [ACHIEVE A SPECIFIC OUTCOME]

.....
so that they can [DEEPER BENEFIT THEY ACTUALLY CARE ABOUT]

.....
without [THE THING THEY DREAD ABOUT THE ALTERNATIVE]

B3 · The validation conversation script

Use this verbatim. Do not pitch. The goal is information, not a sale.

Opening. "I am researching how [ROLE] handle [PROCESS]. Could I ask you three questions? It will take ten minutes and I am not selling anything."

1. "Walk me through how you currently handle [PROCESS]." (*Listen for workarounds and frustration. Do not interrupt.*)
2. "What have you tried to improve it, and what happened?" (*This reveals whether they have ever spent money on this.*)
3. "If this were solved perfectly tomorrow, what would change for you?" (*This reveals whether the problem actually matters.*)

Closing. "This has been really useful. If I build something that does [SPECIFIC OUTCOME], would you want me to show you?" (*A yes here is a weak signal. A "how much will it cost?" is a strong one.*)

B4 · The weekly operating rhythm

When	What	Time
Monday morning	Deep work: the one thing that moves the business	2–3 hrs
Monday afternoon	Cornerstone content produced	90 min
Tuesday	Short-form content extracted and scheduled	30 min
Tue–Thu	Delivery and customer work, batched	2–3 hrs/day
Wed + Fri	Sales: 15 outreach messages, follow-ups	45 min each
Daily	Reactive work — email, support, admin — batched once	45 min
Friday	Weekly review: numbers, what shipped, what to stop	60 min

B5 · The monthly metrics sheet

Track only these. More metrics produce less clarity.

Metric	Why it matters	This month
Revenue	The only score that counts	_____
New customers	Is the top of the funnel working?	_____
Churn / lost clients	Is the product actually good?	_____
Hours worked	Are you building leverage or a job?	_____
Effective hourly rate	Revenue ÷ hours. The health metric.	_____
Content published	The input you control	_____
Conversations had	The leading indicator of everything	_____

B6 · The pre-launch checklist

- ☐ At least five real conversations with target customers, documented
- ☐ The problem written in their words, not yours
- ☐ A specific price, decided using the value case, not by comparison
- ☐ Payment collection working, tested with a real transaction
- ☐ A landing page describing the outcome, not the features
- ☐ At least one person who has used it and said something specific and positive
- ☐ A written answer to "why you?" that is not about passion
- ☐ A plan for the first ten customers that does not rely on going viral

APPENDIX C

Operating From India

Payments, GST, and structure for Indian solo founders

If you are building from India and selling to customers abroad, you face a set of practical questions this book has otherwise treated generically. This appendix covers them. It is general information, current as of mid-2026, and not professional advice — rules change and a chartered accountant is worth the fee.

C1 • The Stripe problem

Many guides written for a global audience assume Stripe. Stripe went invite-only in India in May 2024 and remains unavailable to most freelancers and new businesses. It lacks the cross-border payment aggregator authorisation from the RBI, and where it is available the all-in cost approaches six percent. Plan around it rather than for it.

C2 • How to actually get paid from abroad

Four categories of solution, with materially different economics. The right choice depends on your volume and whether you are selling services or digital products.

Method	Typical cost	Settlement	FIRA	Best for
Bank SWIFT transfer	SWIFT fee + 2–3% FX markup + ~₹250	3–7 days	Paid	Large one-off invoices
PayPal	~4.4% + \$0.30 + ~4% FX spread	1–3 days	Monthly	Convenience; expensive
Razorpay MoneySaver Export	~1%, no FX markup	~1 day	Yes	Services, SaaS, marketplace work
Skydo	\$19 (≤\$2k) / \$29 (\$2k–10k) / 0.3% above	24–48 hrs	Instant	Lower-volume invoicing
Winvesta GCA	\$3 + ~0.99% (USD)	1–2 days	Automatic	USD-heavy invoicing
Payoneer	~2–3% FX markup	2–5 days	Free digital	Upwork, Fiverr, marketplaces
Wise Business	~0.33–2% depending on route	1–2 days	~\$2.50 each	Low-cost conversion

The two things that actually matter

- **FX markup, not the headline fee.** A "1% fee" with a 3% exchange-rate markup is a 4% fee. Compare the rupees that land in your account against the mid-market rate on the day.
- **FIRA/FIRC documentation.** The Foreign Inward Remittance Advice proves you received foreign currency for an export. You need it for GST zero-rating and for clean books. Peer-to-peer transfer services generally do not issue it, which makes them unsuitable for business income regardless of how cheap they look.

One further compliance detail: every inbound remittance must carry a purpose code under FEMA regulations — P0802 for software export, P1006 for royalties, and so on. Modern platforms handle this automatically; banks may ask you to specify it.

C3 · GST on exported services

The good news is that exported services are zero-rated, meaning you charge no GST to your foreign client. Getting that treatment requires meeting conditions and filing one document.

When a service counts as an export

All five conditions must hold simultaneously:

1. The supplier (you) is located in India.
2. The recipient is located outside India.
3. The place of supply is outside India, under Section 13 of the IGST Act.

4. Payment is received in convertible foreign exchange (or in rupees where the RBI permits).
5. The supplier and recipient are separate legal entities — not two arms of the same company.

Remote software development, design, writing, consulting, and online training delivered to a foreign client typically satisfy all five. Services physically performed in India for a foreign client generally do not, and intermediary arrangements are treated as supplied in India.

Registration thresholds

The general threshold for GST registration on services is ₹20 lakh of annual turnover, reduced to ₹10 lakh in special category states. Below that you are not required to register. Many exporters register voluntarily anyway, because registration is what allows you to file a Letter of Undertaking and to claim refunds of input tax paid on your own purchases.

The Letter of Undertaking

The LUT is what lets you invoice a foreign client without collecting IGST and later reclaiming it. File Form RFD-11 on the GST portal. It is valid for one financial year and must be renewed each April. Most registered taxpayers qualify without needing to furnish a bond. Once approved, mark your invoices as a zero-rated supply under LUT.

Your export compliance checklist

- Register for GST (mandatory above threshold; often worthwhile below it).
- File Form RFD-11 (the LUT) — and renew it every April.
- Confirm the place of supply is genuinely outside India for each engagement.
- Invoice with the SAC code, the billing currency, the INR equivalent, and a zero-rated-under-LUT note.
- Obtain the FIRA or FIRC for every payment received.
- Report exports in GSTR-1 Table 6A and in GSTR-3B.
- Ensure payment arrives within one year — beyond that, without an RBI extension, export status can be denied.

C4 · Business structure

Structure	Setup burden	When it fits	Watch out for
Sole proprietorship	Minimal — current account and registrations	Starting out, revenue under roughly ₹40–50 lakh	No liability protection; income taxed at slab rates
One Person Company	Moderate — MCA incorporation, annual filings	Meaningful revenue, want limited liability, sole owner	Compliance cost; mandatory audit above thresholds
LLP	Moderate	Two or more partners; simpler than a company	Not available to a single person
Private Limited	Higher — full compliance and audit	Raising investment, hiring, or planning an exit	Overhead is rarely justified for a true solo business

For most readers of this book, a sole proprietorship with a current account, GST registration where applicable, and a good chartered accountant is the correct starting configuration. Incorporate when there is a specific reason — liability exposure, a client who requires it, or a tax calculation that favours it — rather than because it feels more official.

C5 · Income tax and the presumptive scheme

Beyond GST, your business income is subject to income tax. Two features of the Indian system are particularly relevant to solo operators, and both are worth discussing with an accountant: the presumptive taxation scheme under Section 44ADA for eligible professionals, which allows income to be declared as a fixed percentage of gross receipts and dramatically simplifies bookkeeping, and advance tax, which requires tax to be paid in instalments through the year rather than in a single annual payment.

The habit that prevents a crisis

Move 30 percent of every payment you receive into a separate account on the day it arrives, and treat that account as untouchable. Between GST liabilities, advance tax instalments, and annual income tax, founders who spend gross revenue as though it were net income are the ones facing a serious problem in month fourteen. This single habit prevents almost all of it.

C6 · Pricing for a global market from India

A structural advantage worth using deliberately: your cost base is in rupees and your revenue can be in dollars, euros, or pounds. Two implications follow. First, do not price against the local market when selling internationally — price against the value delivered to the client in their own economy, exactly as Chapter 8 describes. Second, resist the temptation to compete on being cheap. Positioning as the low-cost option attracts the worst clients, invites constant price pressure, and is the single most common way skilled Indian solo operators end up overworked and underpaid.

YOUR ACTION STEPS

- ☐ Choose a payment platform based on total landed cost, not the headline fee.
- ☐ Confirm your chosen platform issues FIRA automatically.
- ☐ If you are GST-registered, file or renew your LUT before invoicing internationally.
- ☐ Open a separate tax account and automate a 30 percent transfer from every payment.
- ☐ Book one hour with a chartered accountant before your first international invoice.

APPENDIX D

Tools and Communities

A directory, with honest notes

Prices are indicative as of mid-2026 and change frequently. Verify before subscribing. Nothing here is a paid placement.

AI assistants and research

Tool	Use	Cost
Claude	Long-document reasoning, careful writing, code review	\$20/mo
ChatGPT	General assistant, images, voice, broad plugin ecosystem	\$20/mo
Perplexity	Research with citations you can verify	Free–\$20/mo
NotebookLM	Reasoning over your own documents and sources	Free

Building

Tool	Use	Cost
Cursor	AI code editor for people who write some code	\$20/mo
Replit	Build and deploy in-browser with AI; non-technical friendly	Free–\$25/mo
Lovable	Describe an app, get working software	\$20–\$40/mo
Bubble	Mature no-code app builder with a real learning curve	Free–\$32/mo
Carrd	One-page sites in under an hour	\$19/yr
Framer / Webflow	Marketing sites with design control	\$15–\$39/mo

Selling and payments

Tool	Use	Cost
Gumroad	Digital products with almost no setup	~10% per sale
Lemon Squeezy / Paddle	Merchant of record — handles global sales tax	~5% + fees
Podia / Teachable	Courses and memberships	\$33–\$99/mo
Razorpay	Payments and international collection from India	~1–3%
Skydo / Winvesta	Low-cost international collection into India	See Appendix C

Content and distribution

Tool	Use	Cost
Beehiiv	Newsletter with growth and monetisation tooling	Free–\$49/mo
Kit (ConvertKit)	Email automation for creators	Free–\$29/mo
Postiz	Publish across 30+ social channels from one workflow	\$19–\$29/mo
Descript	Edit video and audio by editing text	\$12–\$24/mo
ElevenLabs	AI voice and narration	\$5–\$22/mo
Canva	Design without design skills	Free–\$13/mo

Operations

Tool	Use	Cost
Zapier	Automation with the widest integration coverage	\$20–\$30/mo
Make	More powerful branching logic; steeper curve	\$9–\$29/mo
n8n	Self-hosted automation, no per-task cost	Free self-hosted
Notion	Company brain: docs, CRM, content calendar	Free–\$20/mo
Lindy	AI agents for inbox, scheduling, CRM hygiene	Free–\$49/mo
Cal.com	Scheduling without the email tennis	Free–\$15/mo

Research and validation

Resource	Use	Cost
Google Trends	Direction of search interest over years	Free
Exploding Topics	Early-stage trend detection	Free–\$39/mo
Reddit	Where people describe problems in their own words	Free
Similarweb	Competitor traffic and channel mix	Free tier
Ahrefs Free Tools	Keyword difficulty and backlink basics	Free tier

Communities worth joining

- **Indie Hackers** — the longest-running community of bootstrapped solo founders. Revenue transparency is the norm, which makes it unusually useful.
- **Build-in-public on X** — follow founders in your specific niche rather than general business accounts. The peer network matters more than the content.
- **r/Entrepreneur, r/SaaS, r/SideProject** — variable quality, but excellent for observing what problems people actually complain about.
- **Niche-specific Discord and Slack communities** — the highest-value ones are usually the smallest and hardest to find. Ask people in your niche where they gather.

One community, used properly

Joining ten communities and lurking in all of them produces nothing. Join one, introduce yourself, post what you are working on weekly, and reply to other people substantively. The relationships that come from being a genuine participant in one place are worth more than passive membership in twenty.

Sources and further reading

The research underlying this book draws on reporting and data from Fortune, Forbes, Entrepreneur, Carta's solo founder research, Cipher Projects, Nevermined AI, GetStackSmart, EntrepreneurLoop, Karbon, Skydo, Winvesta, TaxAdda, and the public writing of the founders profiled in Chapter 12 — particularly Pieter Levels, Justin Welsh, and Dan Koe, all of whom publish extensively about their own methods and numbers. Reading those founders directly, in their own words, is the single best follow-up to this book.

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